



THE EFFECT OF AN AI-GENERATED ADVERTISEMENT ON CONSUMER ATTITUDES

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ABSTRACT

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The effect of an AI-generated advertisement on consumer attitudes

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Keywords: artificial intelligence, AI advertising, perceived ad creativity, ad attitude, brand attitude

This Master's thesis studied the impact of an ad generated with artificial intelligence on consumers' ad and brand attitudes. Based on prior research, it was hypothesized that disclosing the AI use at the end of a video ad could have positive effects on attitudes. Perceived ad creativity was used as a mediating variable, as its positive influence on AI advertising effects has been theorized in previous literature, but not scientifically established yet. This thesis also addresses a research gap by using a video ad as a stimulus, as most other AI disclosure studies have used image ads or texts as stimuli.

The study utilized an experimental between-subjects design. An online survey was distributed using convenience and snowball sampling techniques and received 53 responses. The respondents saw a video ad focused on bread created with two AI programs. The data received were analyzed using SPSS to test four hypotheses developed based on prior research and two source effects models, the Elaboration Likelihood Model and the Information-Processing Model.

Only one hypothesis received statistical support, indicating that higher perceived ad creativity leads to more positive ad and brand attitudes. This result supports prior research findings. Correlation analysis indicated that older respondents had more positive attitudes towards the ad and brand. However, the low number of survey responses and chosen sampling techniques limit the applicability of the results. The results highlight the need for more research into AI advertising, as there is no clear indication of the AI disclosure's effect on consumer attitudes for video ads.

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Tekoälyllä tehdyn mainoksen vaikutus kuluttaja-asenteisiin

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Tämä pro gradu -tutkielma käsittelee tekoälyllä tehdyn mainoksen vaikutusta kuluttajien mainos- ja brändiasenteisiin. Tutkimuksen tarkoituksena oli selvittää, vaikuttaako maininta tekoälyn käytöstä videomainoksen lopussa myönteisesti kuluttaja-asenteisiin. Koettua mainoksen luovuutta käytettiin välittävänä muuttujana, koska sen vaikutusta asenteisiin ei ole vielä tutkittu tieteellisesti tekoälymainoksia hyödyntäen. Tämä tutkimus myös paikkaa tutkimusaukkoa käyttämällä videomainosta, koska lähes kaikki muut samaa aihetta tarkastelevat tutkimukset ovat käyttäneet kuvamainosta tai tekstiä.

Tutkimuksessa käytettiin kokeellista tutkimusasetelmaa kahden ryhmän välillä. Internetkysely lähetettiin mukavuus- ja lumipallo-otantamenetelmillä mahdollisille vastaajille ja sai 53 vastausta. Vastaajat näkivät leipään keskittyvän videomainoksen, joka oli tehty kahdella tekoälytyökalulla. Saatu data analysoitiin SPSS-ohjelmistolla neljän hypoteesin testausta varten. Hypoteesit perustuivat aiempaan kirjallisuuteen ja kahteen lähdevaikutusten teoriaan, harkinnan todennäköisyyden teoriaan ja informaation prosessoinnin teoriaan.

Vain yksi hypoteesi sai tilastollista tukea. Vastaajien korkeampi koettu mainoksen luovuus johti myönteisempiin mainos- ja brändiasenteisiin, tukien aiempia tutkimuslöydöksiä mainoksien luovuudesta. Korrelaatioanalyysin perusteella erityisesti vanhemmilla vastaajilla oli myönteisempiä mainos- ja brändiasenteita. Alhainen vastausmäärä ja valitut otantamenetelmät kuitenkin rajoittavat tulosten pätevyyttä. Selkeä näyttö tekoälyn käytön vaikutuksesta kuluttaja-asenteisiin jäi puuttumaan, joten lisätutkimus aiheeseen, erityisesti videomainoksia hyödyntäen, on tarpeellista.

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I am also very grateful to all the survey respondents, who dedicated their time for this thesis. I do not know many of the respondents personally, so I owe many thanks to those who helped me without any compensation.

Finally, big thanks to my friend Viktoria. You have been my cheerleader throughout this past year, and I appreciate all the times I could express my frustrations with my studies to you. Thank you for being such a good friend and helping me get more respondents for my survey!

SYMBOLS AND ABBREVIATIONS

Symbols

α	Cronbach's alpha
β	Beta coefficient

Abbreviations

AI	Artificial intelligence
ELM	Elaboration Likelihood Model
IPM	Information Processing Model

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Symbols and abbreviations

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DECLARATIONS

Turnitin

The originality of this thesis has been reviewed with the Turnitin similarity checking service.

AI usage

The author of this thesis, Elina Lankinen, used the following AI tools during the preparation of the thesis:

1. ChatGPT

- a. Purpose of use: ChatGPT was used to develop a narrative for the video ad stimulus to get more AI incorporated into the process.
- b. Explanation of the use of the tool: ChatGPT was prompted to provide a 30-second video ad about a common food product most Europeans would know. Following the first result, the tool was prompted five times to modify the narrative to make it easier to create in video format.

2. Sora

- a. Purpose of use: Sora was used to create video clips for the video ad stimulus.
- b. Explanation of the use of the tool: Sora was prompted with the narrative texts created with ChatGPT to create the videos. Of over 20 videos, six were used in the video ad stimulus.

3. Firefly AI

- a. Purpose of use: Firefly AI was used to create video clips for the video ad stimulus.
- b. Explanation of the use of the tool: Firefly AI was prompted with the narrative texts created with ChatGPT to create the videos. Of five videos, one was used in the video ad stimulus.

Responsibility

The author, Elina Lankinen, takes full responsibility for the content of this thesis and has reviewed and edited the content generated by the possible use of AI tools.

1 Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) has become very prominent in various industries since the launch of ChatGPT in November 2022 (Taulli 2023, p. 11). Numerous other programs able to generate entirely new content, such as images and videos suitable for advertising, have since become easily accessible for people and companies. This has prompted consumers to express their opinions on AI-generated content. For example, the discourse surrounding Coca-Cola's 2024 Christmas ad campaign was the starting point for this thesis. In Winter 2024, Coca-Cola released an AI-generated video ad similar to their 1995 Holidays Are Coming ad (Horvath 2024). The ad received a lot of criticism from creative professionals and social media users, who considered the ad unnatural and lacking a human touch (Horvath 2024). Additionally, Coca-Cola received backlash for not employing actual artists to work on the ad (Horvath 2024). In response, the company pointed out the time and money savings the AI use provided (Muir 2024).

The negative response to Coca-Cola's ad has not prevented other companies from experimenting with AI in advertising. Kalshi, a prediction market company operating mostly in North America, used AI tools to create a video ad shown during the National Basketball League's third game in the championship final series in June 2025 (Chappell 2025). The ad gained more than 3 million views on Kalshi's X account within one week of airing (Chappell 2025), highlighting consumers' interest in the ad. The progress made in AI-generated video ads and their impact on consumers' opinions and attitudes has become an interesting issue for further exploration, suitable for a thesis.

1.1 Background

The use of AI in advertising has been researched since 1990s but the recent surge of new ways to use the technology has increased the number of research articles in the past few years (Ford et al. 2023). Ford et al. (2023) list four main strains of AI advertising research: AI-driven innovations focus on where AI can be used in advertising; computational advertising studies the use of AI applications to automate and optimize advertising;

programmatic advertising examines how to automate media buying; and ad effectiveness studies the impact AI-generated ads have on consumers.

Despite this increase in attention to AI-generated ads, few studies have employed a theoretical base, which limits the current studies' ability to drive forward new theory development (Ford et al. 2023). Additionally, the majority of articles focusing on AI advertising come from authors based in the United States, China, and the United Kingdom (Ford et al. 2023), suggesting that more variety in perspectives would be beneficial for studying the phenomenon.

Ford et al. (2023) also note that enhancing the appeal of AI-generated ads for consumers should be a key research question to pursue in the future. There is some evidence that consumers don't like AI-generated ads if they are informed of AI's role in making the ad (Arango et al. 2023; Baek et al. 2024; Grigsby et al. 2025; Sands et al. 2025), but the results are not conclusive. Crucially, academia has not consistently explored consumers attitudes, which are more indicative of advertising effectiveness when compared to behavior or intentions (Eisend & Tarrahi 2016). Further, Ford et al. (2023) note that human creativity is crucial for managing the effectiveness of AI advertising. However, most studies on AI advertising have not included creativity as a measure, so there is little evidence that this is the case. AI models are able to produce new texts and visuals based on prompts (Feuerriegel et al. 2024), suggesting that they can produce narratives for ad campaigns as well. How much human intervention is required for AI-generated ads, towards which consumers form positive attitudes, is yet to be fully explored.

The focus of this thesis is on ad effectiveness, which Ford et al. (2023) noted was the least explored area of the four between 1990-2022. In particular, it examines the effect of an AI-generated ad on ad and brand attitudes, mediated by perceived ad creativity. These variables were chosen due to the lack of prior utilization in research, despite their crucial roles in developing AI advertising. Additionally, this study employs an AI model in developing not just the ad, but its narrative to further enhance the involvement of AI in the creative process. This thesis creates a theory-based study of the AI advertising phenomenon and adds a new mediating variable to further explain consumer attitudes towards AI-generated ads.

1.2 Preliminary literature review

Traditionally, online ads have been created and edited using digital tools, but access to artificial intelligence and other new manipulation tools has enabled advertisers to create “synthetic ads” as a new method of appealing to consumers (Campbell et al. 2022). While ads have long been manipulated using tools like makeup, lighting, and image editing software like Photoshop, new AI opportunities enable advertisers to create very realistic images and videos with lower costs than before (Campbell et al. 2022; Hartmann et al. 2025). Since generative AI models like DALL-E 3 and GPT-4 are able to produce new content from training data (Feuerriegel et al. 2024), creating online ads has also become easier and faster. With these new advances, using AI in advertising has gained more popularity and researchers have begun to pay attention on consumers’ attitudes and behavior in response to AI-generated ads.

Several studies have looked into how disclosing AI as the creator of a message impacts consumer attitudes. Disclosing the use of AI in image ads has been found to negatively impact consumers’ ad attitudes, perceived ad credibility, and brand attitudes (Arango et al. 2023; Baek et al. 2024; Grigsby et al. 2025; Sands et al. 2025). However, disclosing AI or human as the source of anti-vaping messages caused no significant difference in how participants rated 30 messages (Lim & Schmälzle 2024). Similarly, disclosing texts simulating a brand voice as AI-generated did not negatively impact brand attitudes as consumers did not view the messages less authentic (Kirkby et al. 2023). Most researchers have not utilized video ads as a stimulus in their studies, with the exception of Lee et al. (2025), who showed study participants Adidas video ads recreated with AI. Lee et al. (2025) found that becoming aware of the AI use after seeing the video ad led to more positive ad evaluations, compared to groups who saw the disclosure prior to the ad or not at all. It is possible that seeing the AI disclosure before the ad can lead consumers to focus more on the production of the ad, distracting them from the actual ad content and therefore rate the ad lower (Lee et al. 2025). This thesis seeks to verify some of the findings from the study by Lee et al. (2025) by using an AI-generated video ad as a stimulus with the AI disclosure displayed at the end of the video.

Prior research has identified several moderating and mediating variables which can lessen or even reverse the negative effects of AI-generated advertising disclosure. Baek et al. (2024)

find that consumers' perception of AI's human-likeness moderated the impact of AI disclosure: consumers who find AI more human reacted more positively to the disclosure, whereas consumers who think of AI as a machine had more negative reactions to it. In addition, perceived credibility of the ad mediated ad attitudes, as the group who viewed AI as a machine rated both ad credibility and attitude towards the ad lower than the other group (Baek et al. 2024). Grigsby et al. (2025) note that trust mediates the relationship between AI disclosure and ad attitudes; when AI is considered the message source, trust is reduced and attitudes towards the ad are less positive. Using a mix of human-made and AI generated images in ads can mitigate this effect (Grigsby et al. 2025). Another moderating variable found in previous research is leadership for the greater good (Sands et al. 2025). Leadership for the greater good is described as prioritizing societal well-being in addition to financial benefits, and consumers rate the AI ads more positively if they think the company is engaging in such practices (Sands et al. 2025). Similarly, explaining the motivations of using AI in advertising can help mitigate the negative effects (Arango et al. 2023). Perceived sincerity has also been found to mediate a negative relationship between awareness of falsity (or the use of AI in producing an ad) and online brand engagement (Aljarah et al. 2024).

In addition, ad context and content can influence consumers' attitudes towards AI-generated ads. Chen et al. (2024) found that consumers responded more positively to ads made with AI if they had an agentic appeal. The effect was mediated by task self-efficacy, indicating that consumers feel AI is well-suited to performing objective tasks (Chen et al. 2024). Additionally, they assigned AI a partner or a servant role; the latter helped mitigate or reverse negative attitudes towards AI ads with a communal appeal (Chen et al. 2024). Lee et al. (2025) found that using human models or digital versions of them in sports focused video ads were rated more positively than entirely digital models. It is possible that consumers were familiar with the human models, and therefore their digital versions, and knew more about their expertise, leading to better advertising effectiveness (Lee et al. 2025). Grigsby et al. (2025) find that using real images in AI-generated ads can improve the negative perceptions of AI use in service ads, when the real image is of an important intangible attribute of the service; in their study, an image of a dentist. Song et al. (2024) found that tourists respond more positively to AI-generated ads with rational appeals and human-generated ads with emotional appeals, indicating that incorporating both in marketing can be beneficial. The authors use information processing fluency as a mediator, confirming their expectation that consumers associate AI with rationality and objectivity, and involvement as

a moderator, finding that highly involved tourists consider AI ads with rational appeals more effective (Song et al. 2024). They also find that the rational ads affected tourists' willingness to travel more than emotional appeals did (Song et al. 2024).

To further the research into AI-generated advertising, this study incorporates perceived ad creativity as a mediating variable. A framework by Campbell et al. (2022) for studying manipulated ads highlighted perceived ad creativity as potentially increasing an ad's persuasiveness, but the variable has not been studied in AI-generated advertising research yet. Ad creativity, commonly considered to consist of originality and relevance, has been found to positively influence ad and brand attitudes (Rosengren et al. 2020). Originality refers to the uniqueness of the ad, while relevance indicates that the ad is useful to the consumer (Rosengren et al. 2020). AI can improve both originality and relevance of an ad due to additional customization capabilities it provides for advertisers, such as language changes and tailoring campaigns on customer data (Campbell et al. 2022). However, it is possible that consumers react negatively to AI-generated ads focused too much on creativity, as they realize the ads are not human-made (Campbell et al. 2022). Following the study by Chen et al. (2016), this thesis incorporates creativity as two measures (ad originality and ad relevance) in the research design and analyses.

As creativity has a stronger effect on attitudes than memorization (Rosengren et al. 2020), this study features ad and brand attitudes as the dependent variables. Attitudes can be used to predict consumers' behavior (Mitchell & Olson 1981), with ad attitudes influencing brand attitudes (Ducoffe 1996). Ad attitude is one of the most common constructs in advertising research to measure advertising effectiveness (Li & Ali 2021) and is based on a consumer's willingness to evaluate the value the ad provides for them (Ducoffe 1996). A brand attitude is based on ad attitude in addition to brand and product beliefs (Mitchell & Olson 1981) and is relatively long-lasting (Spears & Singh 2004). As most AI advertising studies have not featured both brand and ad attitudes in their studies, this study seeks to further our understanding of consumer attitudes towards AI-generated ads by including both.

1.3 Research questions

To study the effects of using AI in online advertising on consumer attitudes, the main research question is formed as:

What is the impact of using an AI-generated ad on attitudes towards the ad and brand?

The topic is important to research as more companies seek to increase the effectiveness of their advertising spend by using artificial intelligence (Ford et al. 2023). Consumers have displayed various reactions to AI-generated ads and some ways to mitigate the negative responses have been identified. Still, more research is required into particularly brand attitudes as they have not been studied as much as ad attitudes, even though the two concepts are linked (Spears & Singh 2004). Additionally, consumer attitudes towards the use of AI-generated video ads have not been extensively researched.

In addition to the main research question, three sub questions are posed. The first is:

How does an ad disclosed as AI-generated (vs ad with no AI disclosure) impact perceived ad creativity?

One of the propositions made by Campbell et al. (2022) focuses on the impact of perceived ad creativity: “greater perceived creativity of an advertisement decreases the negative effect of awareness of ad falsity on persuasion outcomes” (p. 31). Therefore, it is important to find out how consumers rate an AI-generated ad in terms of creativity, either knowing it was made with AI or not being informed of that fact. In addition, the ratings give insight into the type of ad content consumers find creative, which can aid in developing stimuli for future research and support managerial decisions on AI-generated ad content.

The second sub question is:

What is the effect of perceived ad creativity on ad and brand attitudes?

It is posed to study whether perceived ad creativity influences the persuasion outcomes of this study, ad and brand attitudes, in a significant way. Although perceived ad creativity has been studied before in the context of advertising effectiveness (Rosengren et al. 2020), this study seeks to confirm the link between these variables in the AI context in order to investigate the next research question.

The final sub research question is:

Does the ad disclosed as AI-generated (vs ad with no AI disclosure) impact ad and brand attitudes either directly or through perceived ad creativity?

To understand whether an AI-generated ad influences consumer attitudes, this study explores the effects between all three variables. In addition, the study's purpose is to verify the mediating effect of perceived ad creativity, so learning more about the variable will aid in future research into the topic.

1.4 Theoretical framework

Source effects have been used as the theoretical base in a few studies related to the use of AI in advertising (Grigsby et al. 2025; Lim & Schmälzle 2024; Lee et al. 2025). Source is the person or company perceived as providing a communication message to a recipient (Tannenbaum 1956). This recipient often brings their current attitudes about the source and the message's content to the communication event (Tannenbaum 1956). These attitudes can be strongly held and influence whether the recipient will change their views and attitudes about the message content and the source itself after receiving the communication (Tannenbaum 1956; Cacioppo & Petty 1986). However, if the content of the message is not personally relevant to the recipient, they might use the source characteristics such as source credibility and likability as well as other non-content cues to assess the message content (Chaiken 1980; Cacioppo & Petty 1986). To study the effectiveness of advertising, several theoretical models have incorporated these basic premises of source effects. The two utilized in this study are the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) and the Information-Processing Model (IPM).

The ELM by Cacioppo and Petty (1986) proposes that consumers process messages through two different routes: central and peripheral. The central route is used when the message recipient has high motivation and ability to assess the message's arguments, creating more long-lasting attitudes (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). The peripheral route is used when the recipient does not want to or is not able to process the arguments, so they rely on peripheral cues such as source characteristics to form attitudes (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). Petty & Cacioppo (1986) note that arguments made in the message become less important for persuasion if the recipient is distracted, increasing the importance of peripheral cues. This is in line with the study by Lee et al. (2025), where the AI disclosure was presented to the participants prior to seeing the AI generated ad; it is possible that the disclosure distracted consumers from the message content and lead them to evaluate the ad using the peripheral

cues instead of the arguments. The ELM suggests that both source and message factors, such as credibility or the number of arguments presented, respectively, can influence information processing and therefore act as peripheral cues (Petty & Cacioppo 1986).

Similarly, Scholten's (1996) revised version of the IPM posits that source and message factors are two of the four antecedents of advertising effects; the remaining two are receiver and channel factors. The source is the person or company who communicates; message factors describe what is communicated and how it is communicated; receiver is the person the message is sent to; and the channel is the method through which the message is sent (Scholten 1996). The IPM also puts forward advertising effectiveness as a sequential process where persuasion, or change in attitude, is mediated by exposure (the consumer being in the audience to receive the message) and retention (Scholten 1996). The IPM is one of the hierarchy of effects models, which explain advertising effectiveness as a hierarchy of intermediate effects occurring on the way to intended behavior, such as repeat purchase (Scholten 1996). To summarize, both the ELM and IPM suggest that message and source factors are important tools for forming attitudes towards ads and brands.

Based on the theories, the framework presented in Figure 1 was developed for this study:

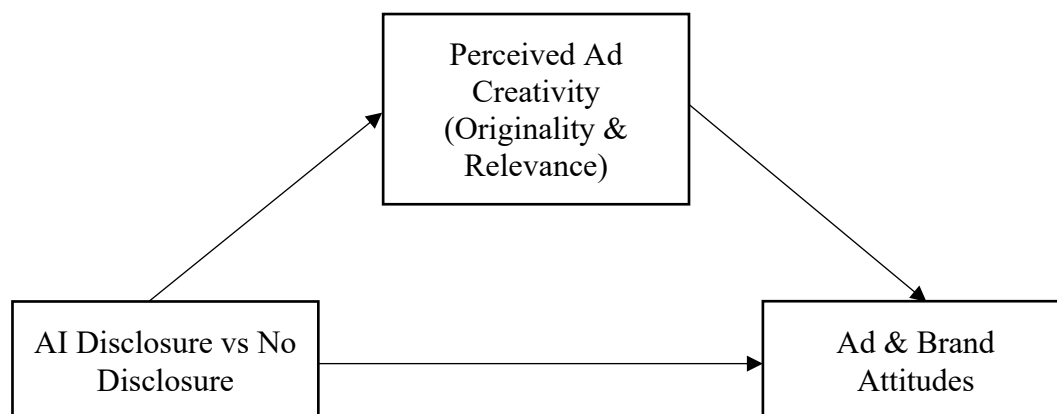


Figure 1. The theoretical framework for studying an AI ad's impact on ad and brand attitudes.

The framework is based on the theory that AI acts as a source for the message. The effect of using an AI disclosure in a stimulus ad is compared to not showing a disclosure at all, with

the assumption that using AI as an additional source will increase ad and brand attitudes directly and indirectly via the two creativity measures, ad originality and ad relevance. The framework and hypotheses development is expanded on in Section 3 of the thesis.

1.5 Key concepts

The study has four main concepts. Artificial intelligence generated advertising can be described as ads created mainly by using an AI technology, such as DALL-E 3 or ChatGPT. This type of advertising is also called “synthetic advertising”, which utilizes AI algorithms like generative adversarial networks (GANs) to create the ads (Campbell et al. 2022). AI-generated ads are generally advanced forms of ad manipulation and it can be very difficult for consumers to differentiate between AI creations and entirely human made ads (Campbell et al. 2022). The benefits of using AI-generated advertising compared to human-created advertising are reduced costs and time commitment of producing the ads (Lee et al. 2025).

Advertising creativity is conceptualized as having original and relevant content in an ad, although more focus has been put on originality (Smith et al. 2007; Campbell et al. 2022). Relevance in this context means that some of the ad content is “meaningful, useful or valuable to the consumer” (Smith et al. 2007, p. 820). Rosengren et al. (2020) define ad creativity as “advertising execution(s) that is (are) original and appropriate” (p. 41). A two-part definition is beneficial, as original ads without relevance or appropriateness are deemed odd (Rosengren et al. 2020). In this study, creativity is split into two measures, ad originality and ad creativity, in the research design, but mostly discussed as a single concept encompassing the two factors. Perceived advertising creativity has been shown to influence attitudes towards ad and brand (Rosengren et al. 2020); for example, it can explain behavioral intentions for mass customized ads and elicit positive attitudes in social media advertising (Aichner & Abdel Monim 2019; Lee & Hong 2016). However, Campbell et al. (2022) suggest that while perceived creativity can enhance the persuasiveness of an ad, it can also make consumers aware of the ad’s falsity, which can promote negative feelings towards the ad.

Attitudes towards an ad and a brand are very commonly used measures in marketing research (Eisend & Tarrahi 2016; Li & Ali 2021). An attitude is an evaluation of an object and categories like good/bad and like/dislike are used to form these evaluations (Li & Ali 2021).

More specifically, attitude towards an ad is a person's favorable or unfavorable evaluation of the ad (Spears & Singh 2004) and these attitudes are mostly researched through explicit verbal statements (Li & Ali 2021). Attitude towards a brand is relatively long-lasting assessment of a brand that guides behavior and is a separate idea from feelings, which are more short-term and fleeting (Spears & Singh 2004).

1.6 Research methodology

The study was quantitative in nature, with a randomized between-subjects experiment with two experimental conditions. This method was chosen for the study due to experiments being one of the most common research methods in advertising research (Geuens & De Pelsmacker 2017). The experiment was done using a video ad with an AI disclosure label absent for the control group and present for the experimental group. The video ad was created by the researcher utilizing two AI models, Sora and Firefly AI, and featured a fictional bread brand. The experiment was conducted through an online survey, where participants first viewed the ad, then responded to questions about the ad, the brand featured in the ad, the ad's originality and relevance, their attitude about AI, their openness to learning, and demographic questions. The survey was distributed using a convenience sample and also snowball sampling to gain more respondents. The survey is available in Appendix 1.

The survey received 53 completed responses, and the results were analyzed using SPSS and the PROCESS macro by Hayes (2022). The analyses included Pearson's correlation coefficient and hypothesis testing with independent samples t-test, linear regression, and Model 4 regression with the PROCESS macro. Additionally, reliability and validity of the measures were analyzed using Cronbach's alpha and factor analysis, respectively.

1.7 Delimitations

This study has some delimitations. From a practical standpoint, the experiment was conducted using just one ad stimulus and did not include a comparison between human and AI generated ads which has been done in some studies (for example, Chen et al. 2024 & Song et al. 2024). Instead, the study's stimulus had two versions, one with an AI disclosure and one with no disclosure at all; this design was also utilized by Baek et al. (2024) and

Arango et al. (2023), for example. This scenario also replicates more closely current types of advertising, which rarely disclose the use of human designers in ad creation. In addition, a research design with disclosures for AI-generation and human-generation, and no disclosure at all was dismissed by the researcher as too complex for the purpose of this thesis. Similarly, the study did not include any comparison between different media, such as images and video.

Some researchers have conducted several studies which are discussed in one research article (for example, Chen et al. 2024, Song et al. 2024, & Grigsby et. al. 2025). However, this research paper features one experimental study for one scenario incorporating the concepts and variables discussed above, as creating multiple studies would have stretched the timeline of the thesis needlessly. Additionally, a field experiment might have provided better insights into the phenomenon, but was dismissed as a research method due to it being more difficult to execute in a short timeframe.

Turning to theoretical delimitations. Concepts which might have been interesting in this context include verisimilitude, or the extent to which an ad looks genuine, and ad falsity, or awareness of the ad's manipulation, which Campbell et al. (2022) identify as other factors influencing an AI-generated ad's persuasiveness. Similarly, various personality traits could have been suitable moderating or mediating variables for this study, as some have been found to influence attitudes towards AI (Kaya et al. 2024). For example, Big Five personality traits like agreeableness might have provided more information about the consumers who find AI-generated ads appealing. These concepts were excluded to keep the thesis simple enough to be completed within a few months by a graduate student with limited experience in creating and executing quantitative studies. Finally, negative attitude towards AI was used as a moderator by Lim & Schmälzle (2024) in a study about AI-generated anti-vaping messages; they found that people with negative feelings towards AI found AI-generated messages more effective than human-created ones. The variable was included in the study and used in the correlation analysis, but it was not the main focus of the study.

1.8 Structure of the thesis

The structure of this thesis is as follows. The next section reviews previous literature in AI-generated advertising, perceived ad creativity, and consumer attitudes towards ad and brand.

Next, the Elaboration Likelihood Model and the Information Processing Model are discussed and the theoretical framework is established in Section 3. Section 4 presents the research design and Section 5 introduces the results. Section 6 includes a general discussion, theoretical and managerial implications, and limitations and suggestions for further research. The thesis concludes in Section 7.

2 Literature Review

Ford et al. (2023) note that future research should focus on how to make AI-generated advertising more palatable for consumers, especially as AI-generated ads are expected to become more and more popular (Huh et al. 2023). Consumers assess the value advertising provides on three different factors: the information it provides, whether it causes irritation, and how entertaining it is (Ducoffe 1996). Since AI-generated advertising can lead to more cost-effective and personalized advertising (Campbell et al. 2022), it provides an opportunity to offer more advertising value to consumers if we understand what they find irritating and entertaining. For example, Nguyen et al. (2024) found that consumers are less concerned about AI advertising if they have access to high-quality information about advertising practices, the ads themselves are relevant and suit the context they are presented in, and the ads' content is easy to understand.

To help research the benefits and drawbacks of AI-generated advertising, Campbell et al. (2022) developed a framework focusing on four main factors related to manipulated ads and consumer responses: manipulation sophistication, verisimilitude, perceived ad creativity, and awareness of falsity. Manipulation sophistication (ad quality) can enhance both verisimilitude (realness of the ad) and perceived creativity, which can increase an ad's persuasiveness (Campbell et al. 2022). However, both can also activate awareness of the ad's falsity which can decrease the intended outcomes (Campbell et al. 2022). Out of the four highlighted variables, awareness of falsity has been researched the most so far (e.g., Aljarah et al. 2024, Arango et al. 2023), while perceived ad creativity has received hardly any attention from academia (Ford et al. 2023). Similarly, studying consumer attitudes should be emphasized in this context as there has been limited focus on them thus far (Ford et al. 2023). Drawing from the hierarchy of effects concept, earlier effects like attitudes explain advertising effectiveness better than later effects like behavior (Eisend & Tarrahi 2016), making them ideal independent variables for the purposes of studying consumer responses to AI-generated ads.

2.1 Consumer reactions to AI-generated marketing

Generative artificial intelligence is a technology with similar capabilities to human intelligence and it develops through continuous learning, being able to process the data it has been given to generate images, text, and audio (Ford et al. 2023; Feuerriegel et al. 2024). The use of AI is becoming more common in marketing, as AI technologies have advanced and new use cases have been identified. For example, AI service agents that fit the brand image of a hospitality company can impact consumers' brand attitudes positively (Liu et al. 2023) and AI recommendation systems can create more precise information, to which consumers react positively (Kim et al. 2021). AI models can also create brand personalities consumers connect with, without any human assistance beyond prompting (Park & Ahn 2024). In addition, AI-generated content has become less expensive than human-created content (Hartmann et al. 2025). For example, the cost of four custom images created by graphic design freelancers can be the same as generating up to 2,500 images with an AI model (Hartmann et al. 2025).

Generative AI can also be used on other marketing applications, in particular advertising. AI-generated advertising, also called synthetic advertising, is a highly advanced form of ad manipulation, which means modifying ads using techniques like makeup, lighting, and retouching (Campbell et al. 2022). AI is a more sophisticated manipulation tool than the previous techniques as it is able to produce entirely new content using generative adversarial networks (GANs) and alter existing content's attributes, creating deepfakes (Campbell et al. 2022). Deepfakes were the first forms of AI-generated ads and widely accessible to regular users without technical backgrounds, who were able to create highly realistic images and videos of people and events which do not exist or have not occurred (Kietzmann et al. 2021).

As it is difficult for consumers to distinguish AI-generated images from human-created ones, AI-generation offers numerous possibilities to make ads more quickly with few marketing professionals (Campbell et al. 2022; Arango et al. 2023). For example, Hartmann et al. (2025) find that for a lower cost, AI models can outperform human graphic designers in image quality, realism, and aesthetic appeal, creating highly realistic and appealing marketing images consumers can't identify as AI-generated. They also found that consumers have better ad attitudes towards AI-generated ads made with DALL-E 3 and Midjourney v6 than towards human-created ads (Hartmann et al. 2025). However, the authors tested seven

different AI models, meaning that the model selection plays a key role in producing ads that consumers find effective (Hartmann et al. 2025). In addition, a banner ad featuring an AI-generated image led to a better click-through-rate than a human-selected stock photograph (Hartmann et al. 2025). The increased efficiency of AI-generated content has prompted researchers to study AI advertising in increasing numbers. Ford et al. (2023) identify four main strains of AI advertising research: “AI-driven innovations in advertising, computational advertising, programmatic advertising, and ad effectiveness in AI advertising”. Ad effectiveness is the least explored area of the four, and Ford et al. (2023) note that in general, not enough attention has been given to consumer responses towards AI-generated ads, ad generation, and creativity. Since the release of their article, many researchers have focused on these issues in particular.

Several previous studies have found that disclosing an ad as AI-generated impacts consumers’ attitudes and feelings negatively. Also known as awareness of falsity, AI disclosure has been used as a variable in several contexts. In charity advertising, disclosing an image and text ad as AI-generated reduced empathy and ultimately donation intentions, through reduced anticipatory guilt and emotion perception (Arango et al. 2023). Similarly, an ad created with DALL-3 and focused on charitable donations was found less credible by people who were exposed to an AI disclosure than by those who were not; the first group also had a less favorable attitude towards the ad (Baek et al. 2024). Disclosing an ad for a new coffee shop as AI-generated reduced reported online brand engagement (Aljarah et al. 2024). Similarly, Sands et al. (2025) also found that using AI-generated ads to advertise a coffee company had a negative impact on brand credibility and brand attitude. AI disclosure also fostered less positive attitudes towards an AI-generated service ad than a human-created ad through reduced trust in the advertised brand (Grigsby et al. 2025). Service ads usually display intangible attributes visually to help customers understand the service experience; if these elements are created with AI, consumers might trust the service provider less and view the AI-generated ad negatively (Grigsby et al. 2025).

To help understand consumers’ negative evaluations of AI-generated ads, the authors manipulated their original stimuli to study mediating and moderating variables that might influence consumers’ reactions. One factor is human-likeness of AI; finding AI more human-like than machine-like mitigates negative effects of AI disclosure (Baek et al. 2024). Similarly, leadership for the greater good, which means the company focuses on societal

welfare and responsibility, also mitigated negative attitudes towards AI-generated content (Sands et al. 2025). In addition, perceived leadership for the greater good led to higher brand credibility, higher brand attitude, and higher purchase intention (Sands et al. 2025). Perceived sincerity, or the extent to which a brand seems genuine in their actions, mediates the negative relationship between awareness of falsity in AI-generated ads and online brand engagement (Aljarah et al. 2024). In other words, as consumers become aware of the AI use, they feel the brand is less sincere and they do not wish to engage with the ads (Aljarah et al. 2024). It is possible this effect is created by the halo effect, or consumers' habit of forming an impression based on a few positive or negative facts and then using that to infer other facts about the person or brand (Aljarah et al. 2024). Trust is also another mediating factor: consumers might be less likely to trust information created by AI and therefore revealing AI as the ad source might reduce the trust a consumer has towards the advertising brand (Grigsby et al. 2025).

One possible explanation for these negative feelings is cognitive dissonance: consumers form perceptions of brands based on their brand personalities and the use of an AI ad can alter these earlier perceptions, creating cognitive dissonance (Aljarah et al. 2024). Consumers wish to reduce cognitive dissonance as much as possible (Aljarah et al. 2024), so they might change their opinions of the brand based on their opinions of AI, which can also be a key aspect influencing their reception of AI-generated ads (Lee et al. 2025). Generally, consumers tend to lean either towards appreciation or aversion of AI algorithms, which influences their opinions of AI-generated content (Lee et al. 2025). However, this effect might not always be negative. For example, Lim & Schmälzle (2024) found that respondents showed a slight bias against AI-generated anti-vaping messages and their effectiveness was moderated by negative attitudes towards AI: those with negative attitudes found AI-generated messages more effective than human-created ones. Interestingly, those who were not aware of the source did not show a similar pattern (Lim & Schmälzle 2024). This indicates that as consumers are not able to distinguish AI-generated and human-created content, their initial reaction to AI disclosure might be negative depending on their own attitudes about AI and the message source, but the message itself can still be perceived as effective.

However, not all studies have found consumers displaying negative feelings towards AI-generated content. Lee et al. (2025) found that AI disclosure in sports-focused video ads

impacted ad attitudes positively. The finding could be due to respondents' personal view on artificial intelligence, as the authors found most respondents held positive attitudes towards AI (Lee et al. 2025). This suggests that using AI to market to those who hold positive views of it can increase advertising effectiveness (Lee et al. 2025). In addition, Lee et al. (2025) note that showing the AI disclosure before or after the ad influences consumers' evaluations: showing the disclosure after seeing the ad yielded higher evaluations from participants, indicating that they might focus more on the content of the ad and less on its production, unlike the participants who saw the disclosure first. However, entirely virtual models were rated lower than human models and their digital twins, indicating that consumers still value some human-like elements in AI-generated ads (Lee et al. 2025).

Ad types, context and content can also impact consumer attitudes towards AI-generated ads. Consumers develop positive attitudes towards AI-generated ads with an agentic appeal, which are more focused on problem-solving and consumers' abilities to complete tasks (Chen et al. 2024). Consumers find these attributes suitable for AI models and therefore find the ads trustworthy, while more communal focused ads perform better if they are created by humans (Chen et al. 2024). Task self-efficacy mediates the impact of AI-generated ads with agentic appeals on consumer attitudes; consumers also find these ads more appealing if AI is positioned as a partner instead of a servant (Chen et al. 2024). For human-created ads with communal appeals, social self-efficacy mediates the effect on attitudes and a servant role is more suitable (Chen et al. 2024).

In tourism advertising, AI-generated ads with rational appeals and human-created ads with emotional appeals work better than the opposite pairings to impact young adults' intentions to visit (Song et al. 2024). The authors discovered processing fluency as a mediator, indicating that consumers process the provided information in the ads slightly differently, depending on the creator type (AI vs human) (Song et al. 2025). In addition, highly involved tourists found AI-generated ads with rational appeals more effective in increasing visit intentions when compared to human-created ads with rational appeals and human-created/AI-generated ads with emotional appeals, but the same was not true for low involvement tourists (Song et al. 2024). Additionally, the negative effects of AI use in charity advertising can be mitigated if the ad is focused on an emergency situation and AI was employed because there were no alternatives for images (Arango et al. 2023). Detailed

explanations of why AI was used were found to be helpful (Arango et al. 2023), although it is not clear how well such texts would work in real life scenarios.

In service ads, using AI-generated images to advertise more tangible attributes and real photographs of intangible attributes, like people providing the service, can mitigate the negative effect of AI disclosure (Grigsby et al. 2025). An explanation for the benefits of adding human-created or focused content in AI-generated ads might be human favoritism: consumers value human-created content and objects more once they are made aware of the human contribution (Lee et al. 2025; Zhang & Gosline 2023). In addition, consumers often initially rate AI-generated content better than human-created when they do not know the creators, but will not decrease their ratings for AI-generated content after gaining that awareness, indicating that the effect might not be a result of algorithm aversion (Zhang & Gosline 2023).

Based on existing literature, a few research gaps arise for exploration. First, few studies have measured the impact of AI-generated ads on both ad and brand attitudes, even though the two measures are closely linked (Spears & Singh 2004; Raja et al. 2023). In fact, it is important to measure consumers' brand attitudes in particular because they can indicate future behavior, such as purchase intentions (Spears & Singh 2004; Raja et al. 2023). In addition, Arango et al. (2023) and Baek et al. (2024) highlight the importance of conducting future research of AI-generated advertising with video ads, as they are a crucial part of many charities' campaigns. Chen et al. (2024) also propose new studies using the video format. Lee et al. (2025) did use video ads in their study of AI-generated sports advertising and ended up with opposite results of consumer attitudes on AI disclosure than other researchers. Therefore, mixed evidence of AI-generated content disclosure causing negative consumer attitudes exists and more research is required.

Studying video ads in this context can be particularly beneficial, as they can be embedded on different media, such as websites, games, and other videos (Jiang et al. 2020). Online audiences can be more selective of the content they consume than television viewers due to the available variety (Jiang et al. 2020). An online advertiser can increase consumers' positive attitudes towards their products and ads if there is congruity between the video ad and the chosen content, as the information in the ad is easier for the consumer to process (Jiang et al. 2020). Using AI to create video ads can reduce the costs of production and allow for more personalized advertising (Ford et al. 2023), indicating that there might be more

opportunities to tailor ad content to different consumers' tastes. In addition, Jiang et al. (2020) note it is important to study how other video characteristics impact consumer evaluations of the ads; one potential aspect of AI-generated advertising mentioned by Ford et al. (2023) and Campbell et al. (2022) is perceived ad creativity.

2.2 Perceived ad creativity

People, processes and outputs can all be described as creative, but in the advertising context, the focus is mostly on outputs such as ads (Rosengren et al. 2020; Vakratsas & Wang 2021). Haberland & Dacin (1992) put forth a concept of creativity that includes four elements: originality, or the extent to which the ad deviates from expectations; appropriateness or meaningfulness, or the way an ad relays something meaningful about its focus and content; reformulation, or the need for the consumer to (re)formulate their attitude about the advertised product or service; and condensation, or the conveying of a lot of meaning or various interpretations within the ad. Since then, creativity has been mainly described as having two dimensions: originality/divergence and relevance/appropriateness (Smith et al. 2007; Rosengren et al. 2020; Campbell et al. 2022). Originality or divergence in this context means unique, novel, or unexpected (Vakratsas & Wang 2021; Campbell et al. 2022; Haberland & Dacin 1992). Smith et al. (2007) put forth that divergence has five dimensions: originality (has elements that are not common or are surprising), flexibility (provides different or new perspectives), elaboration (extends basic ideas to become more complex and detailed), synthesis (combines normally unrelated objects or ideas), and artistic value (verbal details, colors, and shapes). A divergent ad could provide an entirely new concept or idea never seen before, or combine previously seen ad executions in a new manner (Vakratsas & Wang 2021).

Although most studies focus on originality/divergence, it alone does not explain creativity entirely (Smith et al. 2007; Rosengren et al. 2020). Relevance or appropriateness is required to connect the ad to the consumers: if the ad is not appropriate or relevant for them, they will find it odd (Rosengren et al. 2020). Relevance in creativity means that at least parts of the ad or brand are “meaningful, useful, or valuable *to the consumer*” (Smith et al. 2007, p. 820, emphasis authors'). Smith et al. (2008) highlight two types of relevance: ad-to-consumer, meaning the ad contains elements which are relevant to the target customer, or brand-to-

consumer, which means the brand or product category is relevant to the buyer. Therefore, a creative ad has high divergence and high relevance, with divergence being the more influential dimension of creativity for consumer responses (Smith et al. 2007). Importantly, creativity does depend on consumers' perceptions of the ad and their experiences, goals, wants, and needs, so all consumers do not see creativity the same way (Smith et al. 2007). In addition, a high level of creativity might interfere with consumers' comprehension of the ad content as they might be more focused on the executional elements in the ad (Smith et al. 2008).

Ad creativity has a positive impact on all stages of a hierarchy of effects model: brand awareness, learning about the brand, acceptance of the brand's claims, liking the brand, and intentions such as purchase intentions (Smith et al. 2008). However, it has a stronger effect for attitudinal outcomes, such as ad and brand attitudes, than on memorization, indicating that ad creativity is better directed at fostering positive attitudes than leading into long-term recall (Rosengren et al. 2020). The effect is also stronger for ad attitudes than brand attitudes, for high-involvement products than low-involvement, and unfamiliar brands than familiar (Rosengren et al. 2020). Three different models can be used to explain consumer responses to ad creativity: the affect transfer model, which highlights creativity's potential to bring out positive feelings from consumers; the processing model, which signals that creativity can make consumers interested in the ad and brand; and the signaling model, which infers that creativity influences consumers' perceptions about the ad's sender (Rosengren et al. 2020). Of these, the signaling model can explain creativity's effect on brand attitudes the best (Rosengren et al. 2020).

Manipulation sophistication can improve both aspects of creativity, originality and relevance, as the use of AI in ad generation allows tailoring ad content to individual customers based on available data (Campbell et al. 2022). For example, AI generation can reduce production costs by removing the need for photoshoots featuring particular models or celebrities and ease the customization of ad languages and locations (Campbell et al. 2022). Consumers also attribute higher creativity to images made with DALL-E 3 AI model when comparing to human-created images (Hartmann et al. 2025). More creative ads can better capture consumers' attention and increase purchase intentions; however, they are also likely to make consumers more aware of negative issues like customer surveillance (Campbell et al. 2022). Highly personalized and/or unrealistic ads are likely to make

consumers realize they are not human-created, which can lead to two different outcomes: consumers either react negatively to the ads and are not persuaded by the presented information, or they get some added value from the ads, such as increased relevance, which makes them persuasive after all (Campbell et al. 2022). To address the gap in literature, this study will focus on perceived ad creativity as a mediating variable, seeking to investigate some of the propositions made by Campbell et al. (2022) about creativity's role in AI-generated ad effectiveness. More precisely, the study uses the two dimensions highlighted by previous literature, originality and relevance, as separate measures. This follows the design introduced by Chen et al. (2016), where relevance gained more importance as a factor of creativity than previously suggested in literature. Studying the effect of perceived ad creativity in this context provides new insights into the types of AI-generated ad content consumers are willing to accept and how it impacts common consumer responses, such as ad and brand attitudes.

2.3 Attitudes towards ad and brand

Consumer attitudes towards the ad and brand are closely related concepts and have been studied extensively in a variety of advertising contexts (Rhee & Jung 2019). One of the reasons why attitudes are commonly studied in advertising research is the hierarchy of effects concept: earlier effects, such as attitudes, precede later effects, such as behavior, and therefore the earlier effects usually explain advertising effectiveness better than the later ones (Eisend & Tarrahi 2016). Attitudes are also fairly stable and can be used to predict consumers' behavior (Mitchell & Olson 1981). In addition, attitude towards the ad has been shown to influence attitude towards the brand and the effect is stronger if the brand is unfamiliar to the consumer (Ducoffe 1996; Rhee & Jung 2019). However, it is vital to study both as separate constructs: attitude towards the ad forms based on the advertising content, while brand attitudes are also based on previously held beliefs (Mitchell & Olson 1981; Gardner 1985). It is also possible consumers form an attitude towards the ad only if they do not process the brand information presented in the ad (Shimp 1981). In addition, brand attitudes are better indicators of purchase intentions than ad attitudes only (Spears & Singh 2004; Raja et al. 2023).

Attitude towards the ad is one of the most commonly used constructs in advertising research and is primarily intended to measure advertising effectiveness, although it is also a useful construct in explaining the effects of ad exposure to brand attitude (Li & Ali 2021; Ducoffe 1996). Ad attitude has two dimensions: cognitive (consciously processing the executional elements in the ad) and emotional (evoked feelings like love, joy, sorrow) (Shimp 1981). The amount of interest a consumer has towards the ad determines the attention given to it (Shimp 1981); if the consumer gives a lot attention to the ad and evaluates the value it provides, they are more likely to form attitudes about the ad (Ducoffe 1996). Notably, consumers might find ads they do not like valuable, as three factors influence value assessments: the information, irritation, and entertainment provided in the ad (Ducoffe 1996). However, the main persuasive variable in an ad is the source of the message, as consumers use source cues to form beliefs about the ad and brand which lead to attitudes (Eisend & Tarrahi 2016; Mitchell & Olson 1981).

Attitude towards the brand is an internal, relatively long-lasting summary evaluation that most likely precedes behavior (Spears & Singh 2004). Brand attitudes are mainly formed through brand and product attribute beliefs and ad attitudes (Mitchell & Olson 1981; Gardner 1985; Spears & Singh 2004). If the brand is unknown to the consumer, they rely on the ad content to form brand attitudes (Mitchell & Olson 1981). Chang (2012) notes that consumers consider consumption visions the ad provokes relevant when formulating brand attitudes. Consumption visions are mental images of consuming the product, and most likely activated when the ad content is relevant to the consumer (Chang 2012). Shimp (1981) mentions that to evoke positive brand attitudes, companies create ads where the focus is on influencing consumers' beliefs about the positive consequences of consuming the brand, emphasizing the brand's benefits and product attributes. When consumers form brand attitudes, they are assumed to be more rationally than hedonistically motivated to process the ad (Shimp 1981), but they might also unconsciously attach the feelings evoked by the ad to the advertised brand (Gardner 1985). Ultimately, if a consumer processes both the brand-related information and non-brand features (like music and characters) presented in an ad, they are likely to form both ad and brand attitudes (Shimp 1981).

Some other variables, such as the ad's message, the ad recipient's own characteristics, and the brand's communication strategy also influence attitudes towards the ad and brand (Eisend & Tarrahi 2016). In addition, attitudes can be influenced by manipulating the ad

content. More emotional ads produce more positive ad attitudes for unfamiliar brands, while familiar brands with more rational ads create more positive ad attitudes (Rhee & Jung 2019). Using blurred elements in ads for luxury fashion products leads to higher ad and brand attitudes (Rathee et al. 2024), while music used in the ad and endorser attractiveness can also influence both ad and brand attitudes (Raja et al. 2023; Felix & Borges 2014).

As discussed previously in this chapter, the effect of AI-generated content on ad and brand attitudes has been studied from various angles. However, the results so far have been mixed. For example, disclosing brand-related texts as AI-generated did not negatively impact brand attitudes (Kirkby et al. 2023) and while some researchers have found that AI-generated ads result in negative ad or brand attitudes (e.g., Grigsby et al. 2025 & Sands et al. 2025), Hartman et al. (2025) note that consumers have better ad attitudes towards AI-generated ads made with DALL-E 3 and Midjourney v6 than towards human-created ads if they are not aware of the creators. Based on existing research into attitudes, ad content is a significant factor in forming both ad and brand attitudes, but most AI advertising researchers have not measured both attitude concepts in one study. By measuring both ad and brand attitudes, this thesis seeks to better understand their connection in this context.

2.4 Summary

Research into AI-generated advertising and consumer responses is still limited, indicating that there is a lot still left to explore. To summarize, there is no consensus on consumer attitudes towards AI-generated ads; some studies have found that consumers react negatively after being informed of AI use, but opposite results have also been found. Several moderating and mediating variables have been examined, but some researchers have created new stimuli for a replication of their initial studies to measure the mediating and moderating variables or have used prompts to focus consumers' attention on specific details of the ads (Arango et al. 2023; Grigsby et al. 2025; Sands et al. 2025). In terms of ad content, the vast majority of studies have used image and text content, with AI-generated videos being studied only by Lee et al. (2025). A few studies have also found that consumers prefer AI-generated ads with specific type of content (Chen et al. 2024; Song et al. 2024). Perceived ad creativity has not been included as a variable thus far even though it has been shown to be a significant influence on ad and brand attitudes. Finally, most studies into AI-generated advertising have

not measured both ad and brand attitudes, even though the concepts are closely related yet distinct. The purpose of this thesis is to address all of these gaps and help guide future research in AI advertising.

3 Theoretical Framework and Hypotheses

Few of the previous research articles into AI-generated content and advertising have relied on existing academic theories (Ford et al. 2023), but source effects theory is one perspective which has been utilized by several studies (e.g., Grigsby et al. 2025, Lee et al. 2025, Lim & Schmälzle 2024). Source effects theories propose that a message source's characteristics affect a message recipient's attitudes and behavior (Wilson & Sherrell 1993). When a source sends a message to a recipient with an assertion about an object, the recipient brings their original attitudes towards both the source and the object to the communication event (Tannenbaum 1956). The recipient can then change their attitudes based on the source and the message, especially if they hold the source in high regard, or if their initial attitudes towards either the source or the object of the message are not very strong (Tannenbaum 1956). Similarly, the heuristic view of persuasion asserts that recipients use source cues in particular when deciding whether to accept the message's assertion or not, unless the message's object is important or understanding it has significant consequences (Chaiken 1980). In that case, they will more closely evaluate the arguments presented in the message (Chaiken 1980). However, source effects can also provoke the recipient to think more or less about the message content, which also influences the effect source cues have on attitudes (Briñol & Petty 2009). Source effects can also influence self-validation, or the confidence a person has about their own positive or negative thoughts about an object (Briñol & Petty 2009).

There are three main dimensions of source characteristics: credibility, attractiveness, and ideological similarity (Wilson & Sherrell 1993). A source is credible if the statements it makes are considered "truthful and valid" (p. 102) and a recipient might be more prone to accept the statements if they are consistent with the recipient's values (Wilson & Sherrell 1993). Similarly, if the recipient finds the source either physically attractive or ideologically similar, they are more likely to accept the message (Wilson & Sherrell 1993). A particular focus of source effect studies has been credibility, which is mainly based on expertise and trustworthiness (Pornpitakpan 2004). Expertise is the extent to which the source is considered as capable of correctly asserting a viewpoint, while trustworthiness is based on the recipient's view whether the source believes their own assertions as valid (Pornpitakpan 2004). In general, high credibility sources are more persuasive than low credibility ones

(Pornpitakpan 2004; Briñol & Petty 2009), and a source's expertise has been found to have the strongest effect on persuasion (Wilson & Sherrell 1993). Source attractiveness has not been studied as extensively (Briñol & Petty 2009), but some evidence has been found that a source's attractiveness can affect attitude change more if the source is not considered very credible (Pornpitakpan 2004).

Studying AI as a source in the context of advertising, a significant method of communicating brand information to consumers, is a beneficial way of advancing our understanding of consumer attitudes towards AI-generated ads. The purpose of this study is to find out whether disclosing AI as the source influences consumer attitudes positively. Grigsby et al. (2025) mention source credibility theory in their study of AI generated service ads, noting that the message source's trustworthiness and attractiveness influence its effectiveness to shape consumer beliefs and attitudes. Lim and Schmälzle (2024) also note that while credibility, trustworthiness and similarity are commonly studied aspects of source effects, AI has not been examined thoroughly in research as a source. Normally the brand represented in an ad is considered the source, but when consumer is made aware of the AI use in generating the ad, AI becomes the source (Grigsby et al. 2025). Lee et al. (2025) highlight source and message (in)congruence in particular: if the source characteristics and message content do not match, a consumer experiences incongruence and they have to process the information to assign new meanings to the source and message. A high level of incongruence usually leads to negative evaluations.

To continue building on this theoretical perspective, two social psychology models developed from source effects theories are utilized in this study to understand the effect of AI-generated advertising on consumer attitudes. The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) developed by Petty & Cacioppo in 1980 describes two routes of persuasion: the central route, which requires thorough consideration of message arguments, and the peripheral route, which implies the use of cues like source attractiveness (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). Gardner (1985) uses the ELM to explain the effect of ad attitude influencing brand attitude when consumers were tasked to evaluate either brand signals or other ad content after being exposed to the same ad, indicating that consumers might use the central route to supplement the peripheral route to form brand attitudes. The Information Processing Model (IPM), first introduced by McGuire in 1968 and focusing on the antecedents of advertising effects, is another social psychology model developed to study the construct of attitudes (Mitchell &

Olson 1981). Both models have been used previously in advertising effectiveness research but have not been extensively explored in the context of AI-generated advertising.

3.1 Elaboration Likelihood Model

The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) posits that in general, people want to hold correct attitudes about different issues, but their ability and willingness to think about the content of a message varies depending on the conditions and personal factors (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). If a person has high ability and motivation to evaluate information, they are following the central route to persuasion; if their ability and motivation are low, they are following the peripheral route (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). Factors like the message's personal relevance, the recipient's mood, repetition of the message and prior knowledge influence which route the recipient is likely to follow (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). For example, if the message discusses an issue which is important to a recipient, they are more motivated to process the message, therefore analyzing the arguments presented in detail, and less likely to be influenced by the peripheral cues such as source or message characteristics (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). However, if the recipient has low involvement with the issue, their attitudes are more likely to be impacted by cues like message characteristics (Wilson & Sherrell 1993). For example, when prior knowledge of an issue or object is low, the recipient is more likely to rely on peripheral cues presented in the message as their ability to process the arguments is lower than those who are knowledgeable about the topic (Petty & Cacioppo 1986).

Petty & Cacioppo (1986) state that the central route leads to more long-lasting attitudes as it requires the message recipient to evaluate the presented arguments in detail, while the peripheral route is used when the recipient focuses on cues, such as source likability. In addition to argument quality and peripheral cues, a third variable can be used to influence the way a recipient evaluates a message: they can either be directed to or prevented from thinking about the merits and flaws of the argument (objective processing), or guided towards having or not having a certain type of feeling towards the message (biased processing) (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). In addition, the same variable can serve in different contexts as a different variable; for example, the source's characteristics can be scrutinized

even in the central route condition to evaluate the overall merits of the message (Petty & Cacioppo 1986).

The ELM is a sound theoretical base for this study for a few reasons. First, since elaboration of the message is not constrained to be high or low, source characteristics, in this case the AI disclosure, can trigger elaboration in participants (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023). Additionally, by design the survey respondents expect to respond to questions about the ad they see, which indicates they should be highly motivated and able to process it. This presents an opportunity to study whether source characteristics (AI disclosure) do play a role in attitude formation as theorized by the ELM. This expectation is supported by the findings of Lee et al. (2025), which suggest that source characteristics influenced participants' attitudes as the group shown the AI disclosure after seeing the stimulus ad had more positive attitudes than the groups who saw the disclosure before the ad or not at all. The authors speculate that the group who saw the AI disclosure first focused more on the production of the ad rather than its content (Lee et al. 2025). Second, ad creativity has been found to lead to more positive attitudes towards ads and brands (Rosengren et al. 2020). It can be reasoned that creativity is a peripheral cue some participants might use to infer their attitude towards the presented ad and brand. To encourage participants to utilize this particular cue in processing, a low-involvement product is utilized in the stimulus. In addition, using a made-up brand in the ad ensures the participants do not have prior knowledge of the brand or product and forces them to rely at least partially on peripheral cues as suggested by the ELM (Petty & Cacioppo 1986).

3.2 Information Processing Model

Hierarchy of effects models explain the stages a consumer goes through when first developing or changing their attitudes and purchase intentions about a brand (Smith et al. 2008). The models assume a consumer goes through three different stages when processing ad information: cognitive, or building knowledge; affective, or developing feelings and preferences; and conative, or making decisions (Santos & Gonçalves 2021). One of these models is the Information Processing Model (IPM); this thesis utilizes a revised version of the IPM developed by Scholten (1996). This version of the IPM proposes four types of communication factors which precede advertising effects: source, message, receiver, and

channel (Scholten 1996). These antecedents then lead to five stages of advertising effects a consumer goes through in a hierarchical order: exposure to the communication, reception of the communication, persuasion, retention of a new attitude, and finally, behavior based on the attitude (Scholten 1996). The model also presents two postulates; the mediation postulate states that each effect will occur with a certain probability, assuming that the previous effects occurred (Scholten 1996). The situational-weighting postulate indicates that different situations can influence later effects by either blocking them, making them more likely, or having no additional influence (Scholten 1996). Regarding the second postulate, Scholten (1996) uses intelligence as an example: an intelligent person is likely to receive, or understand the communication, but is less likely to be persuaded by it. Similar to the ELM, the IPM and other hierarchy of effects models assume that the consumer is able and motivated to process the message they receive (Santos & Gonçalves 2021).

In general, the hierarchy of effects models are criticized for not considering post-purchase experience, which can influence attitudes (Santos & Gonçalves 2021). In addition, since most of these models, including the IPM, were developed decades before the widespread use of the internet, they do not account for the interaction consumers increasingly have with each other (Santos & Gonçalves 2021). As these two aspects of the consumer journey are outside the scope of this study, the IPM is beneficial for this thesis as it addresses some of the shortcomings of the ELM. First, the model puts forth that both the source and the message content are antecedents to consumer attitudes, which are formed after being exposed to and receiving the message (Scholten 1996). This mitigates the ambiguity of the ELM where variables can serve as either message arguments or peripheral cues (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023). Second, the IPM highlights receiver characteristics more than the ELM, which can be very beneficial in this context, as the respondents were recruited to participate in the study via a convenience sample. For example, their perceptions and attitudes towards AI might influence their view of the stimulus ad. Collecting some data about respondents' backgrounds can be helpful for understanding the results in the context of the IPM model.

3.3 Theoretical Framework and Hypotheses

Based on the discussed theories, this study utilizes the framework presented in Figure 2:

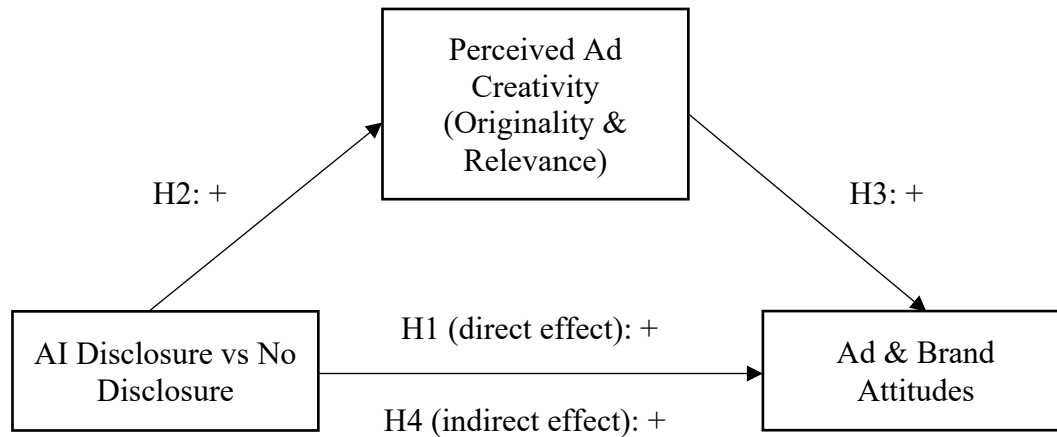


Figure 2. The effect of AI disclosure on consumer attitudes.

Based on the presented theory, the source of an ad message can have an effect on consumers' attitudes towards the ad and the brand seen in the ad. Therefore, this study will feature two different conditions, AI disclosure and no disclosure at all, to investigate the source effect of AI as an independent variable. As suggested by Campbell et al. (2022), perceived ad creativity can be a significant factor in making AI-generated ads more palatable for consumers and therefore its two factors, ad originality and ad relevance, will be used as mediating variables. Finally, this study will focus on consumer attitudes as dependent variables, measuring both ad and brand attitudes.

Four hypotheses were developed based on the framework. Although there are mixed results of the effect AI disclosure has on consumer attitudes, Lee et al. (2025) found that AI disclosure led to more positive evaluations of a sports focused video ad than no disclosure. The authors noted that their respondent base of undergraduate students from various universities had mostly favorable attitudes towards AI, which possibly contributed to the findings. This study also used a video ad in an attempt to verify these results. Additionally, source effects literature proposes that an attractive source can improve recipients' view of the message (Tannenbaum 1956; Wilson & Sherrell 1993), and the ELM suggests that

recipients can use peripheral cues like source characteristics to assess a message if they are not familiar with the brand (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). As this study utilizes a fictional brand, the first hypothesis assumes that respondents use the source information to form attitudes about the ad and brand. Providing the AI disclosure to one of the respondent groups gives them more information about the source, which should lead to more positive attitudes as found by Lee et al. (2025), when assuming that the respondents hold generally positive views of AI.

H1: AI disclosure leads to more positive attitudes towards the ad and brand than no disclosure.

The second hypothesis is based on the suggestion of Campbell et al. (2022) that ad creativity can be enhanced using AI models; consumers might like AI-generated ads they consider highly creative, since it can provide them some additional value. In addition, Hartmann et al. (2025) found that consumers considered AI-generated ads more creative than human created ones. Based on the IPM's situational-weighting postulate, the AI disclosure can enhance perceived ad creativity; if a respondent notices the AI-generated elements in the ad, the AI disclosure can help mitigate the negative effects stemming from awareness of ad falsity and could lead the respondent to consider these elements more creative than they would without the disclosure (Scholten 1996; Campbell et al. 2022). Therefore, the second hypothesis assumes that informing one respondent group about the use of AI in the ad makes them find the ad more creative, or more original and relevant, than the group without this knowledge.

H2: AI disclosure leads to more perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, than no disclosure.

As discussed previously, ad creativity as originality and relevance has been shown to have a positive effect on ad and brand attitudes (Rosengren et al. 2020; Smith et al. 2007). The IPM suggests message factors, or how and what is communicated, has an impact on the stages of advertising effects which include attitudes (Scholten 1996). It can be assumed that the more appealing the message, the more positive attitudes recipients have towards it. Therefore, the third hypothesis is simply stated as:

H3: Perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, increases positive attitudes towards the ad and brand.

Finally, the fourth hypothesis assumes that becoming aware of the AI use enhances the creativity of the ad, which in turn influences attitudes towards the ad and brand positively. This is based on the two main theories presented here: the IPM proposes that source and message factors influence advertising effects such as attitudes, while the ELM suggests that people form attitudes through processing message arguments, peripheral cues like source characteristics, or both (Scholten 1996; Petty & Cacioppo 1986). As Lee et al. (2025) found that consumers reacted more positively towards the ad knowing it was made with AI and consumers might consider an AI generated ad as more creative than a human created one, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H4: AI disclosure leads to more positive attitudes towards the ad and brand through perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, than no disclosure.

4 Research Design

To study the influence of an AI-generated ad on consumers' attitudes towards the ad and brand, a randomized between-subjects experiment was designed. An experiment is a useful way of inferring causal relationships and one of the most common research methods in advertising research (Duman 2021; Geuens & De Pelsmacker 2017). The experiment featured a single-factor design with an AI disclosure label absent or present in a video ad. The ad featured a fictional brand and a low-involvement product (bread) in order to guide consumers to utilize peripheral cues when forming their attitudes (Petty & Cacioppo 1986). Respondents were randomly assigned to one of the two conditions to create a true experimental design (Duman 2021); the control group saw the video ad without the disclosure and the experimental group saw the ad with a disclosure reading "Created with Sora AI". The experiment was conducted using an online survey.

To create the stimulus ad, ChatGPT was used to develop suggestions for the narrative, and Sora and Firefly by Adobe AI models were used to generate five-second video clips which were put together as a 27-second video with iMovie. The purpose was to create an ad for a product most people have experience with. The researcher also assumed the survey respondents could consider the ad as more creative than others in the same category. The video ad focused on a fictional Crüst bread brand with seven scenes developed using Firefly and Sora and background music selected from iMovie's library. The ad begins with a black and white video of bread being torn apart, with the text "They told us bread was boring", followed by a stylish woman eating a piece of bread on the street with the text "We disagreed". The ad then changes to in color and the next videos are various loaves of bread appearing on black backgrounds, with the texts "Introducing Crüst" and "A revolution in crust" appearing. The ad then switches back to two black and white clips of people taking bites of bread with the text "Taste the crust that bites back". The video ad ends with the Crüst logo appearing with the text "The bread. Reinvented." and the AI disclosure label appearing for those in the experimental condition.

The ad was viewed by survey respondents on YouTube, which features video ads before, during, and after other video content. This follows the suggestion by Geuens & De Pelsmacker (2017) that stimuli in advertising research should be placed in a relevant context,

although respondents were directed to view the ad on YouTube from a survey platform. In addition, other advertising research suggestions from Geuens & De Pelsmacker (2017) were followed in developing the stimulus. First, the video ad had a simple concept and included a product (bread) which should be familiar to most respondents, so they would not be confused by the ad. Second, the ad featured a fictional brand in order to eliminate the influence of respondents' previous experiences and associations with a brand.

4.1 Data collection

To collect data, an online survey was set up in Webropol survey tool and distributed to the researcher's friends, family and coworkers using convenience sampling. Snowball sampling was also used as the online survey was further distributed to participants' friends and families. Webropol was chosen as the survey tool due to the convenience of using an electronic format for distributing the survey and collecting responses. In addition, using Webropol was free for the researcher. To comply with General Data Protection Regulation, participants were asked to consent to the survey gathering information about them. They were also informed how their personal data will be stored and protected as required by the Regulation. The data collection period was from June 13, 2025, to June 30, 2025, and the survey link was distributed through Instagram, Facebook, Slack, and WhatsApp. By the end of the data collection period, the survey received 53 completed responses.

The online survey consisted of 32 items, including five demographic questions. The measures included ad attitude, brand attitude, perceived ad creativity split into ad originality and ad relevance measures, AI attitude, and openness to learning. Additionally, a manipulation check was included after measuring the dependent and mediating variables as proposed by Geuens & De Pelsmacker (2017); the check asked whether the respondent remembered seeing an AI disclosure in the ad. Additionally, the items for measuring the mediating variables followed the dependent variable items to discourage the ease-of-retrieval effects (Geuens & De Pelsmacker 2017). The survey is detailed in Appendix 1.

4.1.1 Measures

The independent variable was coded as 0 = control group and 1 = experimental group. Both dependent variables (attitude towards the ad and attitude towards the brand) and mediating variables (ad originality and ad relevance) were measured using multi-item scales (Geuens & De Pelsmacker 2017). Attitude towards the ad was adapted from Chen et al. (2024) and consisted of three items measured with 7-point semantic differential Likert scales, including statements like “This ad is bad/good”, with 1 = “bad” and 7 = “good”, and “I like/dislike this ad”, with 1 = “dislike” and 7 = “like”. Attitude towards the brand was adapted from Spears & Singh (2004) and consisted of five items measured with 7-point semantic differential Likert scales; respondents were asked to describe their feelings about the brand presented in the ad using scales of adjectives like 1 = “unappealing” to 7 = “appealing” and 1 = “unfavorable” to 7 = “favorable”. Perceived ad creativity was adapted from Chen et al. (2016) and was split into two measures, ad originality and ad relevance, as detailed in the prior study. Ad originality consisted of five items, such as “the ad was artistically produced”, and ad relevance consisted of four items, such as “the ad was very relevant for me”, which were all measured on a 7-point Likert scale from 1 = “strongly disagree” to 7 = “strongly agree”. Two other measures were also added due to the researcher’s personal interests and the possibility of correlation with some of the main measures. Attitude towards AI, adapted from Shao et al. (2024), was measured with five items using 7-point semantic differential Likert scales; respondents were asked to what extent they thought using AI technologies were 1 = “bad” or 7 = “good” and 1 = “foolish” or 7 = “wise”, for example. Finally, openness to learning measured with four items using 7-point semantic differential scales with anchors 1 = “not at all” and 7 = “extremely” (Bruner 2021). The items included statements such as “I am open to altering how I see or understand the world” and “I am curious”.

4.2 Data analysis

The collected data was analyzed using IBM SPSS Version 31.0 and PROCESS v5.0 macro by Hayes (2022). Descriptive statistics were analyzed to understand the respondents better, such as the average age and the gender split. In addition, a correlation test was conducted between all variables to investigate their associations using Pearson’s correlation coefficient.

Also called the Bravais-Pearson correlation coefficient, the analysis is useful in understanding whether different variables have a positive or negative relationship, or if there is any relationship at all (Cleff 2025). In addition, the correlation analysis determines the strength of the relationship (Cleff 2025). The manipulation check was analyzed using the “crosstabs” function in SPSS. To test the hypotheses, independent samples t-test was chosen to test Hypothesis 1 (AI disclosure leads to more positive attitudes towards the ad and brand than no disclosure) and Hypothesis 2 (AI disclosure leads to more perceived ad creativity than no disclosure). The t-test is used to identify “the difference between the mean values in two different groups” (Cleff 2025, p. 312) and in this study, was employed to identify any differences between the experimental and control groups. To test Hypothesis 3 (Perceived ad creativity increases positive attitudes towards the ad and brand), linear regression analysis was run. A regression is used to infer causal direction of variables’ association (Cleff 2025), or in this case, whether ad creativity causes more positive attitudes towards the ad and/or brand in a linear fashion. Finally, to test Hypothesis 4 (AI disclosure leads to more positive attitudes towards the ad and brand through perceived ad creativity than no disclosure), regression using the PROCESS macro Model 4 for was run to analyze multiple mediation (Hayes 2022).

4.3 Reliability and validity

Cronbach’s alpha was utilized to measure the reliability of the measures used in this study (Bonett & Wright 2015). Cronbach’s alpha is used to measure the reliability of a measure’s internal consistency when several items are included in the measure (Bonett & Wright 2015). The internal consistency of all measures in this study was at least acceptable. The ad attitude measure consisted of three items ($\alpha = .947$), the brand attitude measure consisted of five items ($\alpha = .955$), the ad originality measure consisted of five items ($\alpha = .720$), the ad relevance measure consisted of four items ($\alpha = .820$), the AI attitude measure consisted of five items ($\alpha = .941$), and the openness to leaning measure consisted of four items ($\alpha = .902$).

To measure the validity of the measures, factor analysis was run using principal axis factoring and the Varimax rotation. Validity is assessed to determine whether the measures actually measure what they are supposed to measure (Litwin 1995). All measures were deemed valid as all loaded on one factor. Ad attitude contained three items and factor

loadings > .907. Brand attitude contained five items and factor loadings > .870. Ad originality contained five items and factor loadings > .491. Ad relevance contained four items and factor loadings > .565. AI attitude contained five items and factor loadings > .827. Openness to learning contained four items and factor loadings > .687. All factor analyses can be seen in Table 1.

Table 1. Factor analysis for all measures individually.

All Items	Ad Attitude	Brand Attitude	Originality	Relevance	AI Attitude	Openness to Learning
This ad is bad/good	.955					
This ad is unappealing/appealing	.907					
I dislike/like this ad	.920					
Unappealing/appealing		.870				
Bad/good		.903				
Unpleasant/pleasant		.911				
Unfavorable/favorable		.905				
Unlikable/likable		.914				
The ad broke away from habit-bound and stereotypical thinking.			.491			
The ad contained ideas that moved from one subject to another.			.527			
The ad connected objects that are usually unrelated.			.405			
The ad finished basic ideas so that they become more intricate.			.690			
The ad was artistically produced.			.815			
The ad was very relevant to me.				.721		
The ad spoke to my concerns.				.735		
The advertised product fits my needs well.				.911		
The advertised product is important to me.				.565		
Bad or good					.918	
Foolish or wise					.827	
Unfavorable or favorable					.864	
Harmful or beneficial					.830	
Negative or positive					.929	
I am open to altering how I see or understand the world.						.687
I want to increase my knowledge.						.936
I am curious.						.829
I am open to acquiring new knowledge.						.925

In addition, discriminant validity was also measured. Discriminant validity is used to indicate if constructs have low enough correlation, so that they can be identified as distinct concepts (Rönkkö & Cho 2022). In this study, the discriminant validity analysis was done with principal axis factoring and the Varimax rotation. The items loaded on six factors, as expected. However, there were a few issues with the loadings, as seen in Table 2 on page 49. Most items load strongly on one factor, with the exception of originality measures, which loaded on two factors. “The ad contained ideas that moved from one subject to another” and “the ad finished basic ideas so that they become more intricate” loaded on factor 5, while “the ad broke away from habit-bound and stereotypical thinking” and “the ad connected objects that are usually unrelated” loaded on Factor 6. In addition, “the ad was artistically produced” from the originality measure cross-loaded on factors 5 and 6. This indicates problems with the originality measure, as the analysis did not load all items on a single factor. “The advertised product is important to me” from the relevance measure also cross-loaded on two measures, or factors 4 and 6. As the ad originality and ad relevance measures are often combined to form a perceived creativity measure (Chen et al. 2016), the result was not entirely unexpected. Also, ad attitude and brand attitude measures loaded on the same factor, which could also be expected as the constructs are closely linked (Spears & Singh 2004).

All measures were collected from prior literature and only the originality and relevance measures were collected from the same study. The expectation was that all measures would load on separate factors. Since this was not the case, the assumption can be made that there is some overlap with ad and brand attitude measures. However, as all measures loaded on one factor in individual factor analyses, the index variables were calculated using all items listed in one measure in previous literature (see Table 1 on page 47). The index variables were then utilized in the hypothesis analyses and correlation analysis. The results of the analyses will take these issues with discriminant validity into consideration.

Table 2. Factor analysis for all items.

All Items	Factor 1: Ad & Brand Attitudes	Factor 2: AI Attitude	Factor 3: Openness to Learning	Factor 4: Relevance	Factor 5: Originality	Factor 6: Originality
This ad is bad/good	.801	.216	.085	.264	.222	.151
This ad is unappealing/appealing	.698	.290	.191	.328	.179	.226
I dislike/like this ad	.741	.281	.063	.379	.296	.138
Unappealing/appealing	.727	.303	.009	.209	.297	.247
Bad/good	.828	.210	.008	.184	.134	.166
Unpleasant/pleasant	.894	.208	-.096	.057	.103	.065
Unfavorable/favorable	.819	.367	.098	.181	.049	.071
Unlikable/likable	.811	.290	.027	.285	.101	.158
The ad broke away from habit-bound and stereotypical thinking.	.269	.360	-.060	.306	.124	.497
The ad contained ideas that moved from one subject to another.	.142	.039	-.021	.287	.564	.110
The ad connected objects that are usually unrelated.	.091	.013	-.023	-.038	.257	.441
The ad finished basic ideas so that they become more intricate.	.332	.119	-.188	-.030	.740	.107
The ad was artistically produced.	.277	.082	-.106	.047	.477	.446
The ad was very relevant to me.	.210	.148	.088	.733	.049	.098
The ad spoke to my concerns.	.379	.098	.037	.633	.246	.030
The advertised product fits my needs well.	.311	.065	-.090	.777	.021	.163
The advertised product is important to me.	.251	.052	.015	.400	-.058	.729
Bad or good	.240	.857	.177	.118	.072	.055
Foolish or wise	.271	.783	-.013	.135	.002	.079
Unfavorable or favorable	.180	.844	.117	-.010	.009	.069
Harmful or beneficial	.319	.757	.177	.077	.034	.073
Negative or positive	.249	.879	.104	.115	.179	-.004
I am open to altering how I see or understand the world.	.150	.078	.681	.016	-.114	-.077
I want to increase my knowledge.	-.057	.071	.928	.050	-.028	.010
I am curious.	.035	.089	.846	-.063	.037	.035
I am open to acquiring new knowledge.	-.018	.130	.901	.048	-.099	-.037

5 Results

The following sections discuss the descriptive statistics of the respondents, the manipulation check, correlations, and finally, hypotheses testing.

5.1 Description of the sample

The survey received 53 completed responses. 26 respondents were assigned to the control group and 27 to the experimental group. In total, 63 respondents began to fill the survey, but 10 respondents did not complete the survey and therefore were excluded from the analysis. Of the 53 respondents, 26 (49.1%) were male, 22 (41.9%) were female, 2 (3.8%) marked “prefer not to answer”, and 3 (5.7%) skipped the question entirely. The average age of the respondents was 38.42 years, with one respondent (1.9%) choosing not to answer the question. The majority (32, 60.4%) of respondents reside in Finland, with 18 (34%) elsewhere in Europe and 2 (3.8%) outside Europe, with one (1.9%) respondent choosing not to answer the question. 9 respondents (17.3%) reported an annual income of 30,000€ or less, the median being 41,000€ - 50,000€ and the mode 31,000€ - 40,000€; one person (1.9%) chose not to answer. Finally, 8 respondents (15.4%) had an education level of high school/vocational school or less, while 3 (5.7%) had a doctorate degree. The median and mode were master’s degree or equivalent. One person (1.9%) chose not to answer the question.

5.2 Manipulation check

A manipulation check was added to the survey to ensure the independent variable was effectively manipulated and this was comprehended by the respondents. The respondents were asked whether they remembered seeing a label indicating the use of AI in the ad and they were able to respond with “yes”, “no”, or “I don’t remember”. There was significant association between the treatment group and remembering seeing the AI disclosure ($\chi^2(2) = 17.10, p < .001$). Of the 26 respondents in the control group, 10 (38.5%) remembered correctly not seeing one, 4 (15.4%) responded seeing one, and 12 (46.2%) did not remember.

In the experimental group, 19 (70.4%) of 27 remembered correctly seeing the label, 2 (7.4%) responded not seeing one, and 6 (22.2%) did not remember. Notably, the control group performed worse in the manipulation check, with just 38.5% remembering not seeing the disclosure correctly, versus 70.4% correctly identifying it in the experimental group. Possible reasons for this include the control group participants not understanding the question, not paying enough attention to the end of the video, or inferring from the video in general that it was made with AI, which then influenced their recall when prompted to think about the AI disclosure.

5.3 Correlation

Several correlations were found between the different measures; the complete correlation matrix is presented in Table 3 on page 53. The following correlations were found at a significance level of at least $p = 0.05$.

Of the main variables grouped together in this study, ad originality and ad relevance are positively correlated ($r(51) = .457, p < .001$), as are ad attitude and brand attitude ($r(51) = .899, p < .001$). Both were expected results based on previous research. However, no strong positive correlation was found between either pair.

Seeing the AI disclosure and education level are positively correlated ($r(50) = .380, p = .005$).

Surprisingly, ad attitude is negatively correlated with gender ($r(48) = .306, p = .031$). Ad attitude is somewhat unexpectedly positively correlated with age ($r(50) = .381, p = .005$). As expected, ad attitude is positively correlated with AI attitude ($r(51) = .546, p < .001$), ad originality ($r(51) = .578, p < .001$), and ad relevance ($r(51) = .647, p < .001$).

Similarly, brand attitude is unexpectedly positively correlated with age ($r(50) = .410, p = .003$) and income level ($r(50) = .294, p = .034$). It is also positively correlated with AI attitude ($r(51) = .557, p < .001$), ad originality ($r(51) = .534, p < .001$), and ad relevance ($r(51) = .566, p < .001$), which could be assumed based on the hypotheses.

Originality is positively correlated with age ($r(50) = .352, p = .011$), and ad relevance is positively correlated with age ($r(50) = .307, p = .027$), which is also somewhat surprising.

Of the descriptive statistics, gender and AI attitude are negatively correlated ($r(48) = .321$, $p = .023$), which was unexpected. Income level and education level are positively correlated ($r(50) = .384$, $p = .005$), which was expected.

AI attitude is positively correlated with ad originality ($r(51) = .320$, $p = .019$) and ad relevance ($r(51) = .305$, $p = .026$), which was expected.

5.4 Hypotheses Testing

Hypothesis 1 (AI disclosure leads to more positive attitudes towards the ad and brand than no disclosure) was tested with an Independent Samples t-test. To compare ad attitudes between the experimental group who saw an AI disclosure ($M = 3.26$, $SD = 1.35$) and the control group who saw no disclosure ($M = 3.85$, $SD = 1.73$), the homogeneity of variance was assessed with Levene's Test for Equality of Variances. The results indicated no significant difference in variance between the groups ($F = 2.605$, $p = .113$). The t-test showed that, assuming equal variances, there was no significant difference in ad attitudes between the experimental and control groups ($t(51) = 1.38$, $p = .175$, 95% CI $[-.27, 1.44]$). Therefore, the null hypothesis can't be rejected. To compare brand attitudes between the experimental group ($M = 3.46$, $SD = 1.34$) and the control group ($M = 3.85$, $SD = 1.62$), the homogeneity of variance was assessed with Levene's Test for Equality of Variances. The results indicated no significant difference in variance between the groups ($F = .837$, $p = .365$). The t-test showed that, assuming equal variances, there was no significant difference in ad attitudes between the experimental and control groups ($t(51) = .950$, $p = .346$, 95% CI $[-.43, 1.20]$). Therefore, the null hypothesis can't be rejected. Overall, the results indicate that AI disclosure does not impact ad and brand attitudes.

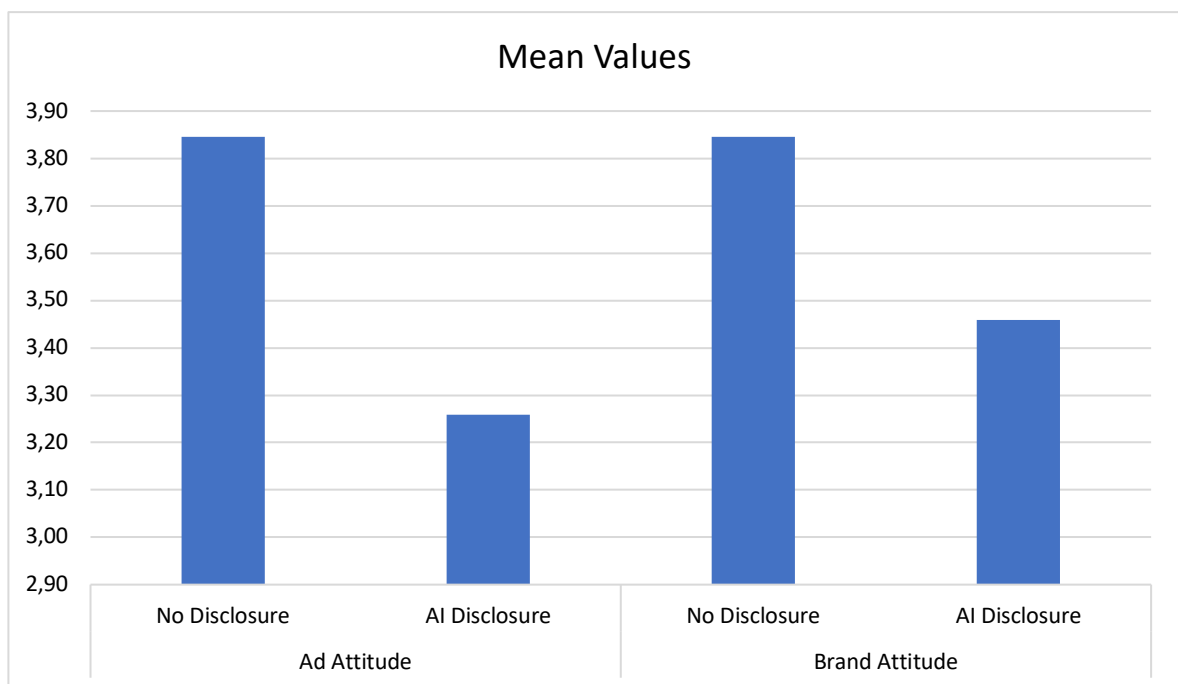


Figure 3. Mean values for Hypothesis 1 testing.

Hypothesis 2 (AI disclosure leads to more perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, than no disclosure) was also tested with an Independent Samples t-test. As perceived ad creativity was split into two measures, ad originality and ad relevance, two separate tests were run. To compare ad originality between the experimental group ($M = 3.52$, $SD = 1.08$) and the control group who saw no disclosure ($M = 4.02$, $SD = 1.12$), the homogeneity of variance was assessed with Levene's Test for Equality of Variances. The results indicated no significant difference in variance between the groups ($F = 0.12$, $p = .914$). The t-test showed that, assuming equal variances, there was no significant difference in perception of ad originality between the experimental and control groups ($t(51) = 1.67$, $p = .102$, 95% CI $[-.10, 1.11]$). Therefore, the null hypothesis can't be rejected. To compare ad relevance between the experimental group ($M = 2.90$, $SD = 1.15$) and the control group ($M = 3.50$, $SD = 1.47$), the homogeneity of variance was assessed with Levene's Test for Equality of Variances. The results indicated no significant difference in variance between the groups ($F = 2.872$, $p = .096$). The t-test showed that, assuming equal variances, there was no significant difference in ad relevance between the experimental and control groups ($t(51) = 1.64$, $p = .107$, 95% CI $[-.13, 1.32]$). Therefore, the null hypothesis can't be rejected. Overall, the results indicate that AI disclosure does not impact perceived ad creativity.

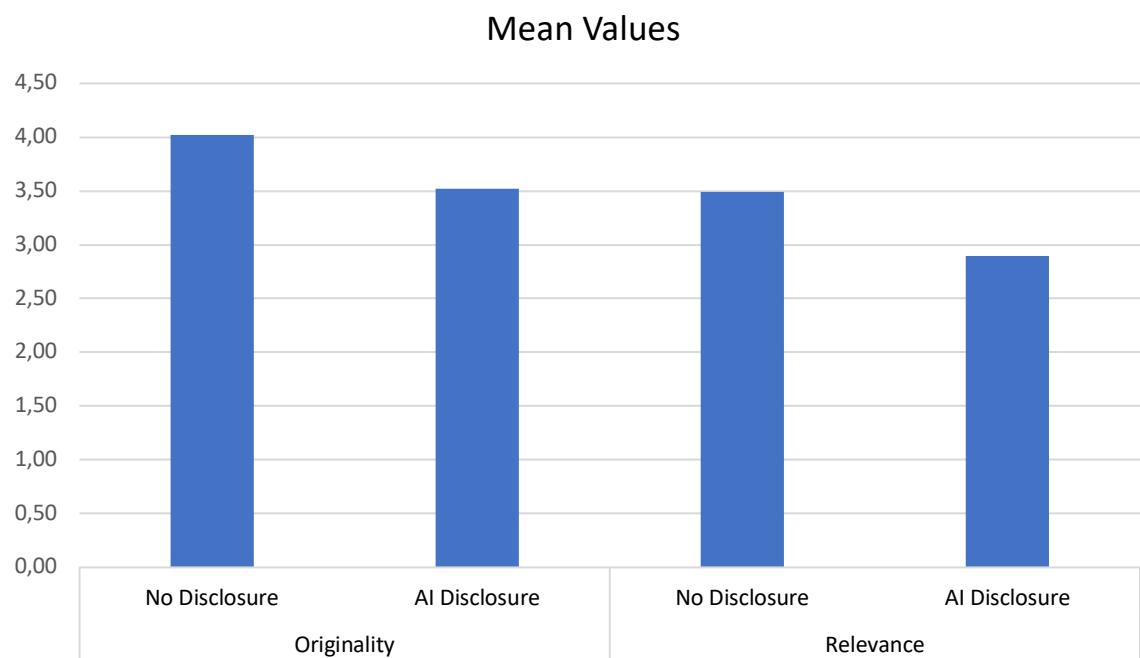


Figure 4. Mean values for Hypothesis 2 testing.

Hypothesis 3 (perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, increases positive attitudes towards the ad and brand) was tested with two separate linear regressions. The first regression's results indicated the two predictors (ad originality and ad relevance) explained 51.9% of the variation in ad attitudes ($F(2, 50) = 27.00, p < .001$). It was found that ad originality (standardized $\beta = .357, p = .002$) and ad relevance (standardized $\beta = .483, p < .001$) significantly predict ad attitude. The second regression's results indicated the two predictors explained 41.7% of the variation in brand attitudes ($F(2, 50) = 17.86, p < .001$). It was found that ad originality (standardized $\beta = .348, p = .006$) and ad relevance (standardized $\beta = .407, p = .002$) significantly predict brand attitude.

Hypothesis 4 assessed the mediating role of perceived ad creativity split into two measures, ad originality and ad relevance, between AI disclosure and ad and brand attitudes (as represented in Figure 5 and Figure 6).

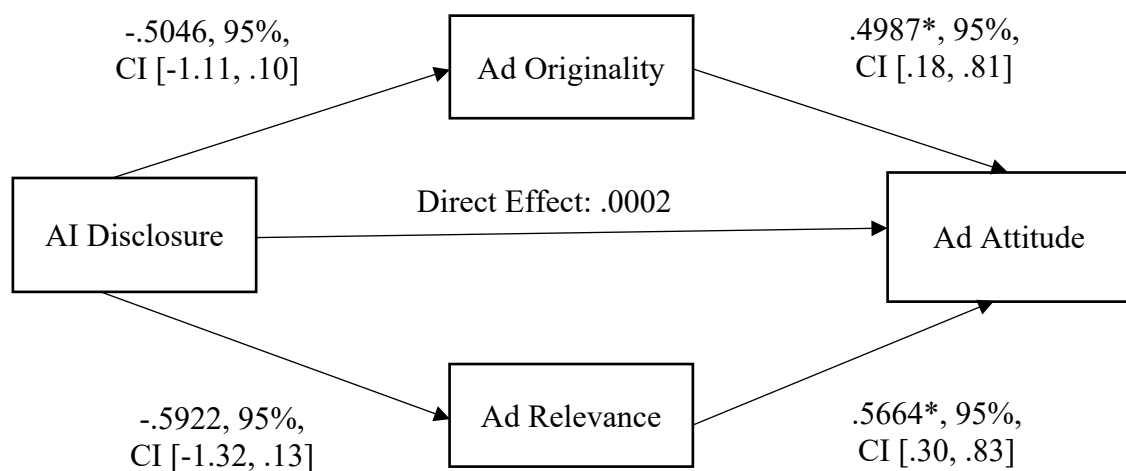


Figure 5. The effect of AI disclosure on ad attitude via ad originality and ad relevance, $*p < .05$.

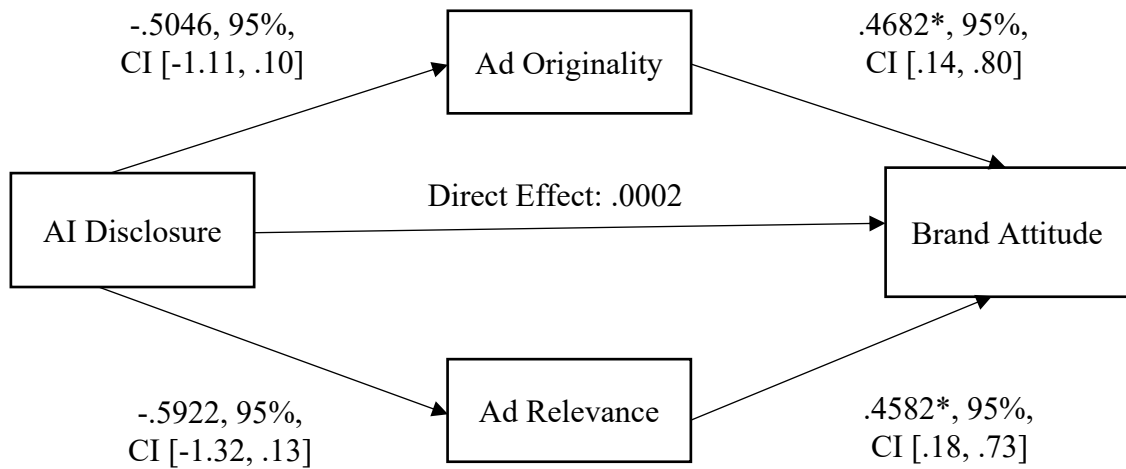


Figure 6. The effect of AI disclosure on brand attitude via ad originality and ad relevance, * $p < .05$.

The results revealed no significant indirect effect of AI disclosure on ad attitude via ad originality (indirect effect = $-.25$, 95%, CI $[-.67, .04]$) or ad relevance (indirect effect = $-.34$., 95%, CI $[-.78, .07]$). The total effect of AI disclosure on ad attitude was $-.59$ (95%, CI $[-1.44, .27]$). There was also no indirect effect of AI disclosure on brand attitude via ad originality ($-.24$, 95%, CI $[-.65, .04]$) or ad relevance ($-.27$., 95%, CI $[-.67, .06]$). The total effect of AI disclosure on brand attitude was $-.39$ (95%, CI $[-1.20, .43]$). Therefore, there is no statistical support for Hypothesis 4.

6 Discussion

This study focused on the impact of an AI disclosure on ad and brand attitudes. The study was based on previous research, which suggested that creativity can improve consumers' responses to AI-generated ads, and two source effects theories, the Elaboration Likelihood Model and the Information-Processing Model. The main research question was: *what is the impact of using an AI-generated ad on attitudes towards the ad and brand?* In addition, three sub questions were included. First, *how does an ad disclosed as AI-generated (vs ad with no AI disclosure) impact perceived ad creativity?* Second, *what is the effect of perceived ad creativity on ad and brand attitudes?* Third, *does the ad disclosed as AI-generated (vs ad with no AI disclosure) impact ad and brand attitudes either directly or through perceived ad creativity?* These questions were utilized to guide the review of previous literature, form the theoretical framework for the study, and create the experiment. To generate new perspectives into the phenomenon, a video ad was used as a stimulus, which has not been common in previous research. The following sections discuss the conclusions drawn from the results of the experiment, the theoretical contributions of the study, and practical implications for advertising managers. This section concludes with some limitations and suggestions for further research.

6.1 General discussion

Based on the research questions, four hypotheses were developed for the study. For Hypothesis 1, AI disclosure leads to more positive attitudes towards ad and brand than no disclosure, there was no statistical support. The hypothesis was based on the similar results from Lee et al. (2025) and source effects theories suggesting an attractive source can improve recipients' thoughts about the message (Tannenbaum 1956). Based on the previous study, it was expected that the control group would have less positive attitudes about the ad, but the opposite was found in this study. The experimental group had a lower mean value for both ad and brand attitude than the control group, indicating the control group rated both the ad and the brand more positively in the survey (see Figure 3 on page 54). The researcher assumed that respondents generally have a positive view of AI, based on discussions with

some of the possible respondents prior to the survey and earlier literature. However, it is likely that some respondents use AI models for certain actions, but dislike AI use in other contexts. Additionally, Lim & Schmälzle (2024) note in their study that consumers can hold negative attitudes towards AI but still find AI-generated messages effective. Therefore, the AI disclosure could have caused the experimental group to react more negatively towards the ad and brand, but the difference in mean values was not significant. Also, there was no significant correlation between AI attitude and seeing the AI disclosure, indicating that AI attitude alone can't explain the lack of support for H1.

Hypothesis 2, AI disclosure leads to more perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, than no disclosure, also received no statistical support. The hypothesis was based on the framework by Campbell et al. (2022), who propose that AI can enhance creativity in ads, and the IPM's situational-weighting postulate, which suggests that different situations can influence advertising effects. It was assumed that respondents would consider the ad creative, but notice it was made with AI. A disclosure explaining the use of AI was thought to lessen the negative effects of ad falsity and lead the respondent to rate the ad's creativity higher. However, the opposite was again true and the control group had higher mean values for the two measures of creativity, ad originality and ad relevance (see Figure 4 on page 55). It is possible the ad was perceived as AI-generated by the majority of respondents, regardless of the group, and the AI disclosure did not influence the respondents' views as theorized. Additionally, as noted by Smith et al. (2007), consumers' perception of the ad and their own experiences influence perceived ad creativity. Therefore, all consumers do not perceive creativity identically. It is likely this influenced the results of the study and the creative elements of the ad were perceived differently by the researcher and the respondents. For example, the ad could have been too creative for some respondents and disrupted their comprehension of the ad's content, as they focused more on its execution (Smith et al. 2008).

Hypothesis 3, perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, increases positive attitudes towards the ad and brand, did receive statistical support. Both aspects of creativity, ad originality and ad relevance, predicted attitudes towards ad and brand, indicating that the respondents who found the ad more creative had more positive ad and brand attitudes. This follows the results of prior research findings, and adds to the body of literature suggesting that both originality and relevance are necessary elements of creativity (Rosengren et al.

2020; Smith et al. 2007; Chen et al. 2016). Similarly, the results suggest that message factors can influence advertising effects, as proposed by the IPM (Scholten 1996).

Finally, Hypothesis 4, AI disclosure leads to more positive attitudes towards the ad and brand through perceived ad creativity, or ad originality and ad relevance, than no disclosure, did not receive statistical support. The hypothesis was based on results from Lee et al. (2025), who found that consumers had more positive attitudes towards an ad once informed it was made with AI, and Hartmann et al. (2025), who note that consumers can find AI-generated images more creative than human-made ones. The expectation was that the experimental group would find the ad more creative due to the AI disclosure, and therefore have more positive ad and brand attitudes. It's possible this result did not occur because the respondents who found the ad more creative were split between the groups, and therefore there is no clear indication of the effect the AI disclosure had on the evaluations. Alternatively, the AI disclosure did not have the desired effect of increasing the perceived creativity of the ad. Additionally, the hypothesis relied on the ELM and the IPM, which suggest that people form attitudes by processing message and source characteristics. Since there was no statistical support for H4, it can be argued that these theories did not sufficiently explain the respondents' attitude formation. However, the results of H1 testing indicate that people who saw the AI disclosure had lower ad and brand attitudes. This can support the idea that respondents utilized source characteristics to form their attitudes; in this case, AI as a source had a more negative effect.

Other factors could have also led to the lack of support for three of the hypotheses. First, the respondents were probably older than in the study by Lee et al. (2025), where the respondents were identified as "undergraduates". In this study, the mean age was slightly over 38 years and all respondents were over 25 years old, indicating that they probably represented a different age demographic than the respondents in the Lee et al. (2025) study. However, there was significant positive correlation between age and ad attitude, brand attitude, ad originality, and ad relevance, indicating the older respondents had more positive feelings about the displayed ad. It is possible that they did not attach importance to the AI use in the ad or did not recognize it as such, as there is no significant positive correlation with age and AI attitude. It could suggest that AI use in advertising is not crucial in increasing or decreasing ad appeal for some consumers.

Second, the fairly low mean for relevance in both groups (see Figure 2 on page 51) indicates that many people did not attach a lot of importance to bread as an advertised product. It is possible the stimulus was too low-involvement and using a more polarizing or trending product could have elicited different responses and ultimately different results. For example, Lee et al. (2025) used Adidas ads, which featured well-known athletes, in their study and indicated that most respondents were familiar with the models. The authors note that sports advertising often focuses eliciting emotional responses on human performance. Similarly, Rhee & Jung (2019) point out that more emotional ads produce more positive ad attitudes for unfamiliar than familiar brands. The stimulus ad used in this study did not seek to evoke very emotional responses, which could have caused indifference in the respondents. Alternatively, Song et al. (2024) found that consumers responded more positively to AI-generated ads with rational appeals. Focusing more on either emotional or rational arguments in favor of bread purchases could have influenced the respondents differently.

Additionally, the ad did not feature a final product, such as a loaf of bread in packaging, which could have been confusing for some respondents and led to lower product relevance. The lack of clear brand signals in the ad could have influenced respondents to focus more on the AI elements of the ad, as source effects literature highlights that if the product is not relevant to the consumer, they use source characteristics to evaluate the ad (Chaiken 1980) or focus on message features other than the arguments (Wilson & Sherrell 1993). For example, it is possible the respondents did not find the ad's overall tone and appearance suitable for the advertised product. This could have impacted not only the relevance measure, but also the measures on ad and brand attitudes.

Finally, it can be assumed that women had more negative AI attitudes and ad attitudes when looking at the correlations. Exploring AI attitudes further was beyond the scope of this study and there is no clear indication whether these attitudes influenced the results for hypotheses testing, but it is worth noting. It is possible women feel more conflicted about using AI in creative fields such as advertising, and it would be interesting learn more about the differences between genders in attitudes towards AI in advertising.

6.2 Theoretical contributions

This study adds to the growing body of research on AI-generated advertising and is one of the first studies to utilize a video ad as a stimulus in an experiment. Despite several studies indicating that AI disclosure on image ads leads to lower ad attitudes and other negative outcomes (Arango et al. 2023; Baek et al. 2024; Grigsby et al. 2025; Sands et al. 2025), studies on video ads and AI-generated texts have not yielded identical results (Lee et al. 2025; Kirkby et al. 2023). This study, while not finding support for the hypothesis that AI disclosure leads to more positive ad and brand attitudes, also did not provide support for the opposite. Creating videos is more challenging than creating images, so it is possible that consumers recognize the opportunities AI models provide in video creation and editing, leading to less negative views of AI-generated video ads. This study highlights that consumers' feelings and attitudes about AI are very complex and understanding them will require further research, especially on video advertising.

As mentioned earlier, the study found that perceived creativity increases ad and brand attitudes, offering support to prior research (Rosengren et al. 2020; Smith et al. 2007). This also showcases that ad creativity is still relevant in modern advertising and deserves to be studied further in the context of AI-generated images and videos. Finally, the variety in respondents' age provided interesting results as age correlated positively with ad and brand attitudes. Many studies are geared towards students, which limits the applicability of the results (Lee et al. 2025; Kirkby et al. 2023). Since the age range in this study was wide, the youngest respondent being 25 and oldest 88 years old, it offers a new perspective on AI advertising research. The results indicate there is much to be gained if older consumers are also included in AI advertising research, as their views on AI might differ significantly from younger adults in other studies as well.

6.3 Practical implications

Despite the mostly non-conclusive nature of the results, some managerial suggestions can be made. As noted earlier, those who found the stimulus ad original and relevant had more positive attitudes towards the brand and ad. Utilizing the two factors of creativity, ad originality and ad relevance, will continue to be important in advertising generated with AI

models. As discussed by Campbell et al. (2022), AI models offer countless options to enhance creativity in advertising, so managers should not be afraid to explore new types of ads AI models can produce in different industries. Since consumers' views on creativity can vary significantly, only by exploring further and creating new ads we can learn more and create new guidelines for AI advertising.

As noted in many other studies, disclosing the use of AI in an ad can reduce positive attitudes towards it, but it might be essential to keep consumers' trust. Navigating the disclosure issue by placing it at the end of a video ad could be an option to stay truthful with the audience, while still ensuring the ad is viewed and processed without a potentially negative influence at the beginning. Additionally, correlation between age and ad & brand attitudes indicate the products and services marketed for older adults can also be advertised using AI. They might not have strong opinions on AI use, which might lead them to enjoy AI-generated ads, or they might not be able to distinguish the AI elements well enough to finding them irritating or distracting. This is yet another avenue of AI advertising which requires further research in academia and real-life business examples.

6.4 Limitations and future research

This study has a few limitations. First, the limited number (53) completed responses to the survey limits the applicability of these results. Geuens & De Pelsmacker (2017) note that a sample of at least 60 participants is suitable for advertising research, but the researcher was unable to motivate enough people to respond. In addition to the completed responses, 10 respondents began to fill the survey but did not complete it. Since the survey platform did not record any identifying information, it was not possible to identify the respondents and ask them to complete the survey. Similarly, the final respondent group was not a representative sample of any particular population, as the survey was distributed to the researcher's friends and family. A larger respondent group limited to a specific age range or nationality could have impacted results significantly.

Second, a notable number of respondents in the control group failed the manipulation check. Over 50% responded incorrectly to whether the ad had an AI disclosure, with 15.4% responding "yes" and 46.2% responding "I don't remember". This indicates the manipulation of the independent variable was not very successful and could have impacted

the results. One possible explanation is that most respondents recognized the video as AI-generated and therefore had that thought at the forefront of their minds when responding to the survey. In addition, the video ended with a black screen with some text (the fictional logo and text “The bread. Reinvented.”), which could have influenced the control group respondents to mistakenly remember seeing an AI disclosure, although it was not present on their version of the stimulus.

Third, Geuens & De Pelsmacker (2017) propose that mediation should be studied through experimental causal chain designs, or through several experiments, but doing several studies was not practical for this thesis due to the limited timeline. Creating a second experiment to manipulate the original stimulus and measure the influence of ad creativity could have led to different results and helped identify elements the respondents actually considered creative.

Fourth, creating the fictional video ad with Sora and Firefly AI models limited the functionality of the stimulus. van Berlo et al. (2024) note in their article about the MADE framework for AI-generated research stimuli that AI-generated video is not at the same level of quality as images, and therefore is not quite as easy to use as a stimulus in research. Although there are many AI models able to produce videos, the researcher had to settle for Sora and Firefly due to cost considerations. Many platforms, such as Invideo AI, have a monthly fee and charge extra for additional AI elements, which can increase the cost by hundreds of euros per month. Therefore, the researcher chose to utilize a free trial period for Firefly and spend 20€ for one month of Sora access. Using a more advanced model intended for continuous video creation instead of 5-second video clips could have improved the stimulus quality. Alternatively, using an AI-generated video ad based on an existing ad, as done by Lee et al. (2025), could have also improved the stimulus. Ads are often generated by advertising professionals, but the stimulus utilized in this study was developed by a student with no advertising background.

Finally, there are some limitations to the ELM as a model explaining attitude formation (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023). The main critique is based on the ambiguity of the variables; for example, since source characteristics can be either peripheral cues or arguments, nearly all findings can support the ELM (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023). Other notable criticisms are the model’s lack of predictive power, argument quality and their manipulation, and questionable suitability for the 21st century’s advertising landscape (Kitchen et al. 2014). In addition, some scholars argue that the unimodel is more representative of how people form and change

attitudes (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023; Kitchen et al. 2014). The unimodel suggests that all information presented in a message are evidence rather than separate arguments and cues, indicating that there is just one route to persuasion (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023). However, the same critique can be applied to the unimodel as to the ELM: since it does not distinguish between different ways an element affects persuasion, it supports nearly all types of findings (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023). Therefore, it is not a superior model which can easily replace the ELM (El Hedhli & Zourrig 2023).

Due to the popularity of AI models and their rapid evolution, future research should continue to focus on advertising applications for AI, the development of AI-generated ads, and consumer responses to them. Some of the previous contexts for AI-generated advertising research have included charity fundraising, coffee shops, and tourism (Arango et al. 2023; Sands et al. 2025; Song et al. 2024), but a wider range of contexts is required. Industries focused on business-to-business commerce could present interesting opportunities for further research, as most studies have explored consumer-facing services and goods.

Additionally, the comparison study between AI-generated images and videos could yield more knowledge on consumer preferences and what might be the ideal method of employing AI in advertising. Video ads are already very prominent in advertising, but their use in AI advertising research has been limited. Identifying the best models for video ad generation could be beneficial to advertising managers; a similar study has already been done to identify the best AI models for image generation (Hartmann et al. 2025).

As mentioned by Ford et al. (2023), more research is still required on consumer responses to the AI-generated advertising, so concepts like consumer attitude, intention, and behavior should be at the forefront of future research into these topics. An interesting theme to study could be attitude differences by age groups, as highlighted earlier in this thesis. To sum up, AI-generation offers limitless possibilities, not just for marketing professionals, but for researchers as well. Exploring all possible aspects of AI generation in advertising will take time but can yield practices benefiting everyone.

7 Conclusion

This study looked into the effect of AI use in advertising on ad and brand attitudes, focusing on creativity as a mediating variable. Past AI advertising research has focused on AI disclosures, ad types, and advertising contexts. This study sought to understand the effect an AI disclosure at the end of a video ad had on ad and brand attitudes via two creativity measures, ad originality and ad relevance. Four hypotheses were developed based on prior research and theoretical frameworks, assuming an AI disclosure in a video ad had a positive influence on perceived ad creativity and ad and brand attitudes. Only one of four hypotheses received statistical support, indicating that higher perceived creativity leads to more positive ad and brand attitudes. Despite the lack of support for the assumption that AI disclosure improves ad and brand attitudes, the study called attention to the importance of studying AI-generated video ads and exploring different respondent groups for experiments. The use of AI in advertising is still in its infancy, and more research into consumer responses can help us identify the most beneficial ways of utilizing AI in marketing.

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Appendix 1. Online survey for the experiment

Elina Lankinen's Thesis Survey

 Mandatory questions are marked with an asterisk (*)

Welcome to my thesis survey! In this survey, you will view a video ad and respond to some questions regarding the ad and your background. The survey should take no longer than 10 minutes to complete, but you must complete it in one sitting. To begin, please click the "Next" button.

Informed consent:

Your participation in this survey is entirely voluntary and you can withdraw your consent or exit the survey at any time. To exit the survey, just close your browser window.

There are no risks to participating in the survey beyond the risks associated with regular computer use. Your responses will be confidential and anonymous, and all responses including demographics (e.g. age) are only reported and analyzed in aggregate form.

If you have any questions, concerns, or complaints, please contact the researcher at elina.lankinen@student.lut.fi.

By clicking the "Next" button, you indicate you are 18 years of age or older, have read and understood the description of the survey, and agree to participate.

Data Protection Notification:

Please familiarize yourself with the privacy notice of this study by copying and pasting this link to a new browser: <https://www.dropbox.com/scl/fi/5t2riiduzhi9x01pu89l4/GDPR-Data-protection-notification.pdf?rlkey=we66bypkvatmx0bmpy4tne4bc&st=lraaumn&dl=0>

If you have any questions or concerns about the privacy notice or data protection, please contact the researcher at elina.lankinen@student.lut.fi.

Please note that if you don't agree to the collection, storage and protection of your data as stated in the notice, you can't participate in this survey. There are no negative consequences if you choose not to participate.

By clicking "Next", you agree to the collection, storage, and processing of your data as stated in the data protection notification.

On the next page, you will get a link to view the video ad. Make sure sound is turned up on your device, then copy and paste the link to a new browser window. Watch the entire ad before returning to the survey.

1. Please copy this video ad link to a new browser window:

<https://youtu.be/o0TtX-cUzUQ> *

☐ I have viewed the ad.

2. Please copy this ad video link to a new browser window:

https://youtu.be/5ag_9L8tU5g *

☐ I have viewed the ad.

Please describe your feelings about the ad you just saw.

3. This ad is: *

[illegible]

4. This ad is: *

[illegible]

5. I dislike/like this ad. *

[illegible]

Please describe your overall feelings about the brand described in the ad you just saw.

6. Unappealing/appealing *

1							7
Unappealing	2	3	4	5	6		Appealing
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

7. Bad/good *

1 Bad	2	3	4	5	6	7 Good
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

8. Unpleasant/pleasant *

1 Unpleasant	2	3	4	5	6	7 Pleasant
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

9. Unfavorable/favorable *

1							7
Unfavorable	2	3	4	5	6		Favorable
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

10. Unlikable/likable *

1 Unlikable	2	3	4	5	6	7 Likable
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

11. Please describe your feelings about the ad you just saw. *

	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Slightly Disagree	Neutral	Slightly Agree	Agree	Strongly Agree
The ad broke away from habit-bound and stereotypical thinking.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The ad contained ideas that moved from one subject to another.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The ad connected objects that are usually unrelated.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The ad finished basic ideas so that they become more intricate.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The ad was artistically produced.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

12. Please describe your feelings about the ad you just saw. *

	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Slightly Disagree	Neutral	Slightly Agree	Agree	Strongly Agree
The ad was very relevant to me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The ad spoke to my concerns.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The advertised product fits my needs well.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The advertised product is important to me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

13. Please recall the ad you saw earlier. Was there a label indicating the use of AI in the ad's creation? *

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ I don't remember

Please indicate to what extent you think using AI (artificial intelligence) technologies is

	1 Not at all	2	3	4	5	6	7 Extremely
I am open to acquiring new knowledge.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

20. What is your gender?

- ☐ Male
- ☐ Female
- ☐ Other
- ☐ Prefer not to answer

21. What is your age? Please write a number.

_____ years

22. Where do you reside permanently?

- ☐ Finland
- ☐ Elsewhere in Europe
- ☐ Outside Europe

23. What is your annual income after taxes?

- ☐ Less than 10,000€
- ☐ 10,000€ - 20,000€
- ☐ 21,000€ - 30,000€
- ☐ 31,000€ - 40,000€
- ☐ 41,000€ - 50,000€
- ☐ More than 50,000€

24. What is your education level?

- ☐ Middle school or less

- ☐ High school/vocational school
- ☐ Bachelor's degree or equivalent
- ☐ Master's degree or equivalent
- ☐ Doctorate degree or equivalent

Thank you for your participation in this survey!

Please note that the video ad you saw earlier is entirely fictional.

If you have any feedback or questions, please contact me at elina.lankinen@student.lut.fi

Please click "Submit" to finish the survey.